

Global Migration 1826–2226: A 200-Year Forecast

WAVES, DRIVERS, CRISES, AND CONTROL REGIMES — EVIDENCE, SCENARIOS, AND THE LIMITS OF LONG-RANGE FORECASTING

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Opening Summary

- **Major migration waves, 1826 to today:** Two centuries of migration can be read as a succession of great waves, each shaped by the same underlying forces — gaps in wages and opportunity, demographic pressure, conflict, and, increasingly, environmental stress — but moving through very different corridors as the world economy reorganized itself. What can be measured with confidence begins with the...
- **Who moves: demographic composition of migrants over time:** The composition of the world's migrants — where they come from, where they go, and how those patterns have shifted over thirty years — is best read through migrant-stock data, which captures the accumulated outcome of decades of movement. The picture that emerges is one of growing diversity of origins alongside persistent concentration of destinations.
- **Regional dimensions: Africa, the Americas, Europe, Asia-Pacific, Middle East and North Africa:** Migration's regional systems differ profoundly in scale, direction, and what drives them. The previous section mapped the stock geography; this section examines what makes each region's migration distinctive.

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Two centuries of movement: the long history of migration

Major migration waves, 1826 to today

Two centuries of migration can be read as a succession of great waves, each shaped by the same underlying forces — gaps in wages and opportunity, demographic pressure, conflict, and, increasingly, environmental stress — but moving through very different corridors as the world economy reorganized itself. What can be measured with confidence begins with the modern statistical record: the UN DESA estimates are widely acknowledged as the main global data source on international migrants, and analysis of long-term migrant stock trends is what allows insight into where people migrate to and which countries they emigrate from. That record comes with a caveat the sources themselves stress: migration flow statistics are limited to specific, narrow geographies, and migration statistics are not as well developed as those in other domains.¹

The geography of movement has inverted and diversified across the two centuries. The classic age of mass migration moved people primarily from Europe outward; today, countries in Europe and Asia feature as both origin and destination countries for tens of millions of migrants each, and the single largest corridors in the world run from South Asia to the Gulf states — Bangladesh, Pakistan, India, Nepal, and the Philippines to Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Oman, Kuwait, and Bahrain. These corridors are overwhelmingly male and labor-driven, ordered by the share of male migrants in corridors exceeding 100,000 persons. The shift from a transatlantic system to a multipolar one — with the Gulf, North America, and Europe as the principal destinations and South Asia, the Philippines, and parts of Africa and Latin America as the principal origins — is the defining geographic fact of the contemporary era.¹

A second defining pattern is the relationship between development and emigration. Cross-country evidence shows emigrant stocks rising with GDP per capita through roughly \$10,000 (2011 PPP) before falling at higher incomes — the “migration hump” documented by Clemens and others — meaning development first increases, then decreases, emigration pressure. This matters enormously for any 200-year forecast: as long as large parts of the world sit on the rising slope of that curve, prosperity alone will not stem outflows.¹

Alongside the regular channels, a vast irregular economy moves with the waves. UNODC estimated at least 2.5 million migrants were smuggled in 2016 alone, generating \$5.5–\$7 billion — roughly equivalent to the entire humanitarian aid budget of the United States or the European Union that year. Smuggling operations range from lone actors to sophisticated transnational networks, often loosely linked through social networks and digital technology, which complicates enforcement. On the Central Mediterranean route, more than a third of surveyed youth reported working without receiving expected payment, and 14 percent reported being forced to work against their will, most often in transit countries before crossing to Italy.²³

The governance of these waves is itself young. The 2018 Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration — grounded in the 2030 Agenda, with foundations dating to the early 2000s — was the first comprehensive multilateral framework for migration, followed by the 2022 International Migration Review Forum and its unanimously adopted Progress Declaration. Two centuries of movement thus end the present era with something historically novel: an agreed global architecture for managing mobility, however unevenly implemented. Whether that architecture can absorb the pressures of the next century — demographic divergence, climate displacement, and the sheer scale of aspiration in youthful societies — is the question the rest of this report takes up.¹

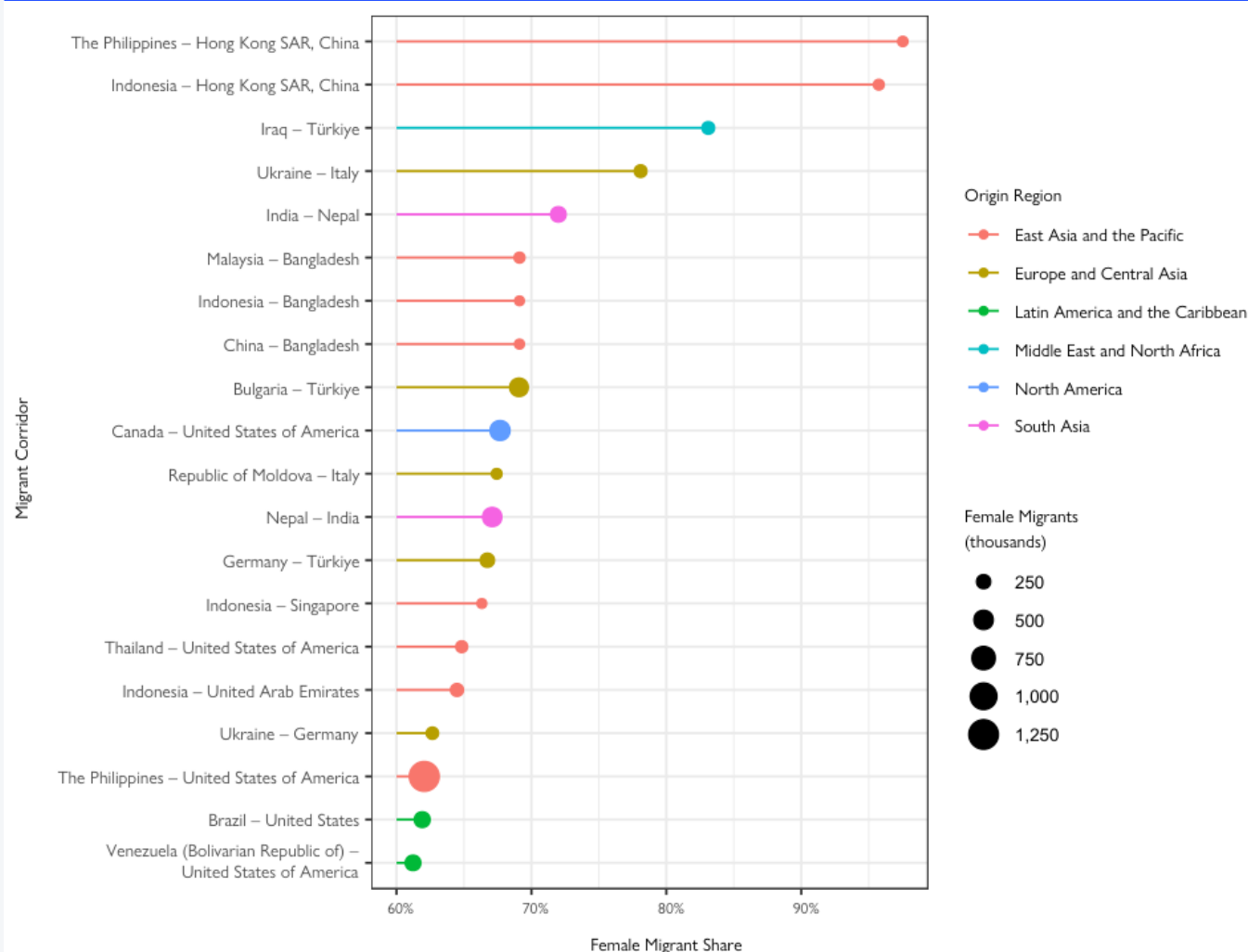


Exhibit. Figure 6. Top 20 female dominant migrant corridors, 2020 The Philippines – Hong Kong SAR, China Indonesia – Hong Kong SAR, China Iraq – Türkiye Ukraine – Italy Origin Region India – Nepal East Asia and the Pacific Malaysia – Bangl. Source: S0001.

Who moves: demographic composition of migrants over time

The composition of the world's migrants — where they come from, where they go, and how those patterns have shifted over thirty years — is best read through migrant-stock data, which captures the accumulated outcome of decades of movement. The picture that emerges is one of growing diversity of origins alongside persistent concentration of destinations.

Asia is the demographic center of gravity of global migration. Home to around 4.6 billion people, it was the origin of over 40 percent of the world's international migrants — around 115 million people — in 2020. Strikingly, most Asian migrants stay within Asia: 69 million resided in other Asian countries in 2020, up from just 35 million in 1990, making intra-Asian movement the largest regional migration system in the world. Beyond the region, 23 million Asian-born migrants lived in Europe and 17.5 million in Northern America in 2020, both growing over the preceding two decades.¹

Europe's migrant population reached nearly 87 million in 2020, up almost 16 percent since 2015. Just over half — 44 million — were Europeans living in another European country, a figure that rose from 38 million in 2015; the non-European migrant population in Europe exceeded 40 million. The mirror image tells its own story: in 1990, roughly as many Europeans lived outside Europe as non-Europeans lived in Europe, but the number of Europeans abroad mostly declined over the subsequent thirty years and only recently returned to 1990 levels, with around 19 million Europeans residing outside the continent in 2020. Europe has thus completed a historic transformation from the world's great source region to one of its principal destinations.¹

Northern America hosted nearly 59 million migrants in 2020, up around 3 million since 2015, and the number has more than doubled over thirty years on the strength of emigration from Latin America and the Caribbean and Asia, alongside the region's economic growth and political stability. Latin America and the Caribbean supplied the largest share — around 26 million — followed by Asia at 18 million and Europe at around 7 million. For Latin America itself, the northward journey dominates: over 25 million people from the region lived in Northern America in 2020, up from an estimated 10 million in 1990, while another 5 million lived in Europe — a number that has more than quadrupled since 1990. Oceania, by contrast, is the smallest system: 8.3 million migrants from outside the region in 2020, composed primarily

of people from Asia and Europe, with the Asian-born component growing steadily over thirty years while the European-born component held steady — and Oceania had the lowest out-migration of any of the six global regions.¹

Forced displacement follows a sharply different compositional logic than economic migration. Where economic migrants depart from a wide range of countries, most refugees come from a limited and shrinking set of origins: crises in just six countries — Ukraine, Syria, Venezuela, Afghanistan, South Sudan, and Myanmar — account for 76 percent of all people in need of international protection. Refugee movements are also more sudden, more concentrated, and carry far larger shares of vulnerable people than economic flows. Development, over time, can narrow that gap: stronger resilience, better skill matches with destination labor markets, and improved conditions at home all reduce the need for distressed cross-border movements.²

The compositional story of the last thirty years, then, is intraregional growth (especially within Asia), the diversification of origins, Europe’s reversal from source to destination, and a forced-displacement system concentrated in a handful of crises. The next sections ask what drives these patterns — and whether they will hold for the next two hundred.

Regional dimensions: Africa, the Americas, Europe, Asia-Pacific, Middle East and North Africa

Migration’s regional systems differ profoundly in scale, direction, and what drives them. The previous section mapped the stock geography; this section examines what makes each region’s migration distinctive.

The Gulf states of the Middle East represent the most extreme case of migration-dependent economies anywhere in the world. In the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait, and Qatar, migrants comprise 88 percent, nearly 73 percent, and 77 percent of the national populations respectively. Most come from India, Egypt, Bangladesh, Ethiopia, and Kenya, working in construction, hospitality, security, domestic work, and retail; the 2022 football World Cup underscored both the importance of migrant labor to the subregion and the rights violations surrounding it. The Gulf is also among the world’s great remittance engines: Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Qatar posted outflows of around \$39 billion, about \$18 billion, and over \$12 billion respectively, placing all three among the top 20 sources worldwide.¹

Asia-Pacific contains both the largest migration system and the smallest. Intra-Asian movement — 69 million people in 2020 — dwarfs every other regional flow, while Oceania’s 8.3 million migrants make it the smallest of the six global regions, composed primarily of Asian- and European-born residents, with the Asian-born component growing steadily over thirty years as the European-born component held flat. The region’s newer story is conflict displacement: Thailand recorded more than 633,000 conflict-driven movements in 2025 — 196,000 in a first round of fighting and another 437,000 in December — already by far the largest conflict displacement event ever recorded in the country, with most of the displaced fleeing rural border areas to government evacuation shelters. Myanmar recorded nearly 573,000 conflict displacements in 2025, a sharp drop from more than 1.2 million the year before.¹⁴

In the Americas, the defining structure remains the northward system centered on the United States, which dominates Northern America’s migration picture; the region’s migrant population has more than doubled in thirty years on emigration from Latin America and the Caribbean and Asia. South Asia’s displacement profile is increasingly disaster-shaped: Pakistan’s 2025 floods left millions homeless, and an earthquake struck Nangarhar province in eastern Afghanistan in September 2025, each generating large-scale internal displacement tracked across successive flash updates.¹⁴

Africa’s displacement is dominated by protracted conflict. In the Democratic Republic of Congo, violence forced millions to flee multiple times through 2025, with displacement tracking, protection analyses, and return assistance running continuously across North Kivu and beyond. Europe, meanwhile, has settled into its role as a destination continent — its transformation from source to destination, detailed in the previous section, now defines its politics as much as its demography.⁴

The regional picture matters for the 200-year forecast because each system’s future hinges on different variables: the Gulf on labor demand and rights regimes, Asia on intraregional integration, the Americas on U.S. policy, Africa on conflict resolution, and South Asia on disaster resilience. The drivers behind these systems are examined next.

Drivers of migration

Demographic trends: aging destinations, youthful origins

The single most durable driver of migration over the next two centuries is demographic divergence: populations aging and shrinking in today’s destination countries while remaining young and growing in today’s origin regions. The World Development Report 2023 frames the consequence bluntly as “the coming competition for workers”. Labor markets in aging societies will bid for workers; youthful societies will supply them. The question is not whether this pressure exists, but how it is channeled — through regular pathways, irregular ones, or not at all.²

The opportunity motive dominates. Over 80 percent of migrants move in search of opportunities in the destination country, and their movements are gradual, with predictable trends reflecting medium-term economic and demographic patterns. In 2020, about 84 percent of migrants (and naturalized citizens) lived in a country with an income higher than that of their country of origin. Yet the largest welfare gaps do not produce the largest flows: where people come from largely determines where they go, and movements are mainly determined by the demand for skills in destination labor markets. Demography sets the potential; labor-market structure decides which potential becomes movement.²

The age profile of movers skews young — and the youngest movers reveal the sharpest edge of the trend. The Central Mediterranean route is the most perilous for children on the move, yet it is also the most common for children migrating from the Sahel and the North and Horn of Africa toward Europe, accounting for 49 percent of children's movements to Europe. Italy received 27,420 children in 2023, a 36 percent increase from 2022 — the highest of any European country — and 69 percent of them (18,820) were unaccompanied and separated, 81 percent aged 15–17, and 88 percent boys. In 2024, most sea arrivals to Italy departed from Libya (63 percent), with significant numbers from Tunisia (29 percent) and Türkiye (5 percent). These are overwhelmingly young males from youthful societies attempting the most dangerous available route — a demographic signature as much as a policy failure.³

Measuring the demographic future is hampered by the same data gaps that afflict migration statistics generally. Population censuses remain the primary data sources on global migration, with near-universal coverage enabling comparability across countries and time, but they are insufficient on their own; the Global Compact for Migration made accurate, disaggregated data its first objective precisely because definitions, collection methods, and dissemination diverge so widely. Large gaps persist across countries and over time, and much administrative data remains beyond the reach of researchers.²

For the 200-year forecast, the demographic logic cuts both ways. Aging destinations will face structural demand for workers that no plausible fertility rebound can fill quickly, creating a persistent pull. Youthful origins will generate cohorts for whom migration is the rational response to local labor-market mismatch — especially where the migration hump keeps emigration pressure rising with early development. Whether that pressure resolves into managed labor mobility or into the boats of the Central Mediterranean depends on the policy architectures examined later in this report.

Economic drivers: wage gaps and demand for skills in destination countries

If demography sets migration's potential, economics decides its volume and direction. The core mechanism is straightforward — workers move toward higher wages and stronger labor demand — but the structure of that demand, and who is allowed to meet it, shapes everything from corridor geography to the politics of receiving societies.

Temporary migration pathways are the workhorse of the global labor-mobility system. They account for almost all migrants in the Gulf Cooperation Council countries, Malaysia, and Singapore, and they are used across the skills spectrum in EU countries to fulfill labor demands; Korea has introduced them as well. The dominance of temporary channels in the world's largest corridors — South Asia to the Gulf above all — means that much of global labor migration is explicitly circular by design: workers admitted to fill a demand, expected to leave when it ends.²

That demand spans the entire skills distribution, and migrants are often more educated than the native workforces they join. In many destination countries, the share of immigrants and naturalized citizens with tertiary education exceeds the average for the labor force as a whole — a pattern visible across Canada, the United States, Australia, the United Kingdom, Switzerland, and the Gulf states alike. The stereotype of the low-skilled migrant captures only part of the flow; destination economies are bidding for skills at every level, from construction labor to software engineering.²

The structural backdrop is aging. The share of people over 65 rose from 7.9 percent to 20.1 percent between 1950 and 2022, threatening the social contract around elder care and pension systems. This is not a cyclical downturn but a permanent recomposition of the labor force: as the ratio of workers to dependents falls, the economic value of each additional worker rises, and with it the pull on migrants. Urbanization compounds the effect — the share of the world living in cities rose from 37 percent to 56 percent over fifty years, transforming how people connect, what they expect, and where opportunity concentrates.²

Economics also drives migration in reverse, through destruction rather than attraction. The Syrian conflict reduced average annual GDP growth by 1.2 percentage points in Iraq, 1.6 in Jordan, and 1.7 in Lebanon — cumulatively 11.3 percent of the three countries' combined 2010 GDP — while generating large-scale internal displacement and external migration. Collapsing economies don't just push their own citizens out; they drag down neighbors, widening the very gaps that propel movement.⁵

For the 200-year forecast, the economic logic points to persistence: as long as wage gaps are large and destination labor markets are tight — conditions aging virtually guarantees — the incentive to move will outrun every barrier erected against it. Policy can redirect these flows into regular channels or push them underground, but it cannot repeal the arithmetic.

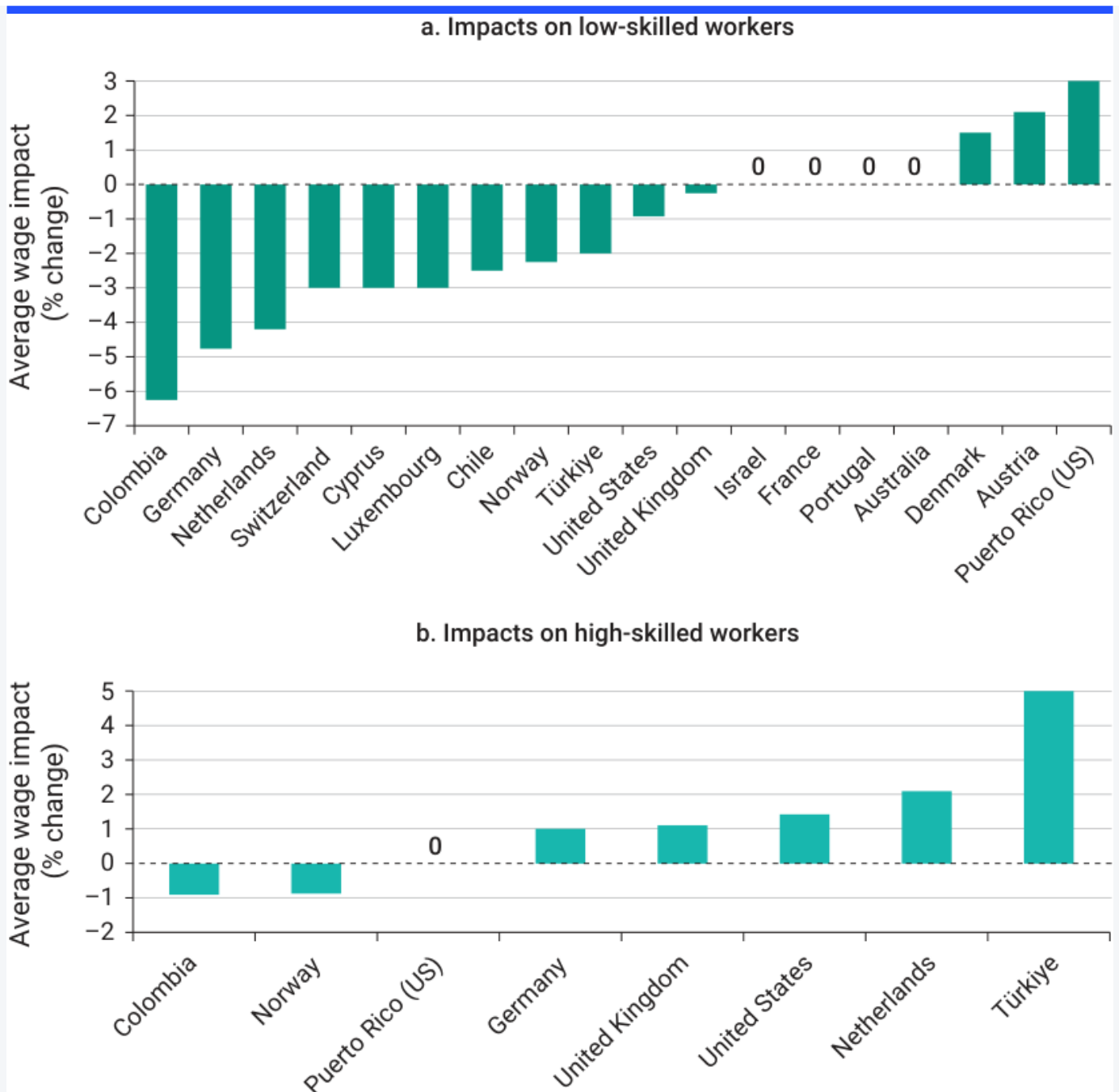


Exhibit. Figure 6.3 The impacts of immigration on wages vary across countries a. Source: S0010.

Theories of why people move

Migration theory has never settled on a single explanation, because no single explanation fits. The evidence supports several overlapping accounts, each capturing part of the movement — and each with different implications for what the next two centuries hold.

The oldest account is the simplest: people move toward opportunity. It remains the most empirically robust — the vast majority of migrants move in search of better prospects — but it needs the qualifier that opportunity is mediated by structure. The Human Development Report tradition adds a crucial reframing: mobility is not only a natural part of human history but a continuing dimension of development itself, the means by which people connect to emerging opportunities and change their circumstances. Internal migration makes the point at scale: an estimated 136 million people have moved within China alone and 42 million within India — totals that, for just two countries, approach the global stock of people who have crossed international frontiers. Development does not merely cause migration; migration is how development happens for the people living through it.⁶

A second account centers on compulsion rather than choice. People who flee insecurity and violence typically see an absolute collapse in their human development outcomes — yet migration still protects them from the greater harm of staying. The 1951 Refugee Convention's protection framework has allowed millions to reach safe environments, though most displaced people relocate within or near their home regions rather than to distant continents. Forced-migration theory thus predicts concentration and proximity, which matches the observed pattern of a few crises generating most displacement.⁶

A third account emphasizes networks and cumulative causation: once corridors form, they persist because information, financing, and social ties lower the cost of each subsequent move. This is why origin so strongly predicts destination, and why established corridors — from Latin America northward, from South Asia to the Gulf — deepen over decades rather than dispersing.

A fourth, newer account treats environmental pressure as a threat multiplier. Climate change has already reached approximately 1°C above preindustrial levels and is likely to hit 1.5°C between 2030 and 2050, bringing more frequent extremes as well as slow-onset impacts — shifting rainfall, sea-level rise, ocean warming — with documented effects on health, income, food security, and water supply for roughly 40 percent of the world’s population. Climate rarely acts alone; it compounds the economic and demographic drivers above.²

Finally, policy itself is a theory of movement in practice. Harsh immigration policies have been observed to promote trafficking and smuggling rather than stopping movement, while ILO conventions on migrant-worker standards have never attracted wide endorsement — states guard their discretion. Conversely, regularization works at scale: over 6 million people applied to move from irregular to legal status in Europe in the decade to 2007, with an 80 percent approval rate, led by Italy’s 1.5 million. And public opinion is less restrictionist than politics suggests: over 60 percent of respondents in developed countries believe legal migrants should have the opportunity to stay permanently.⁶

The theories converge on one forecast-relevant conclusion: the structural drivers — demography, wage gaps, networks, climate — all point toward more movement, while policy determines only its form. Theories of why people move are, in the end, theories of which channels the future will use.

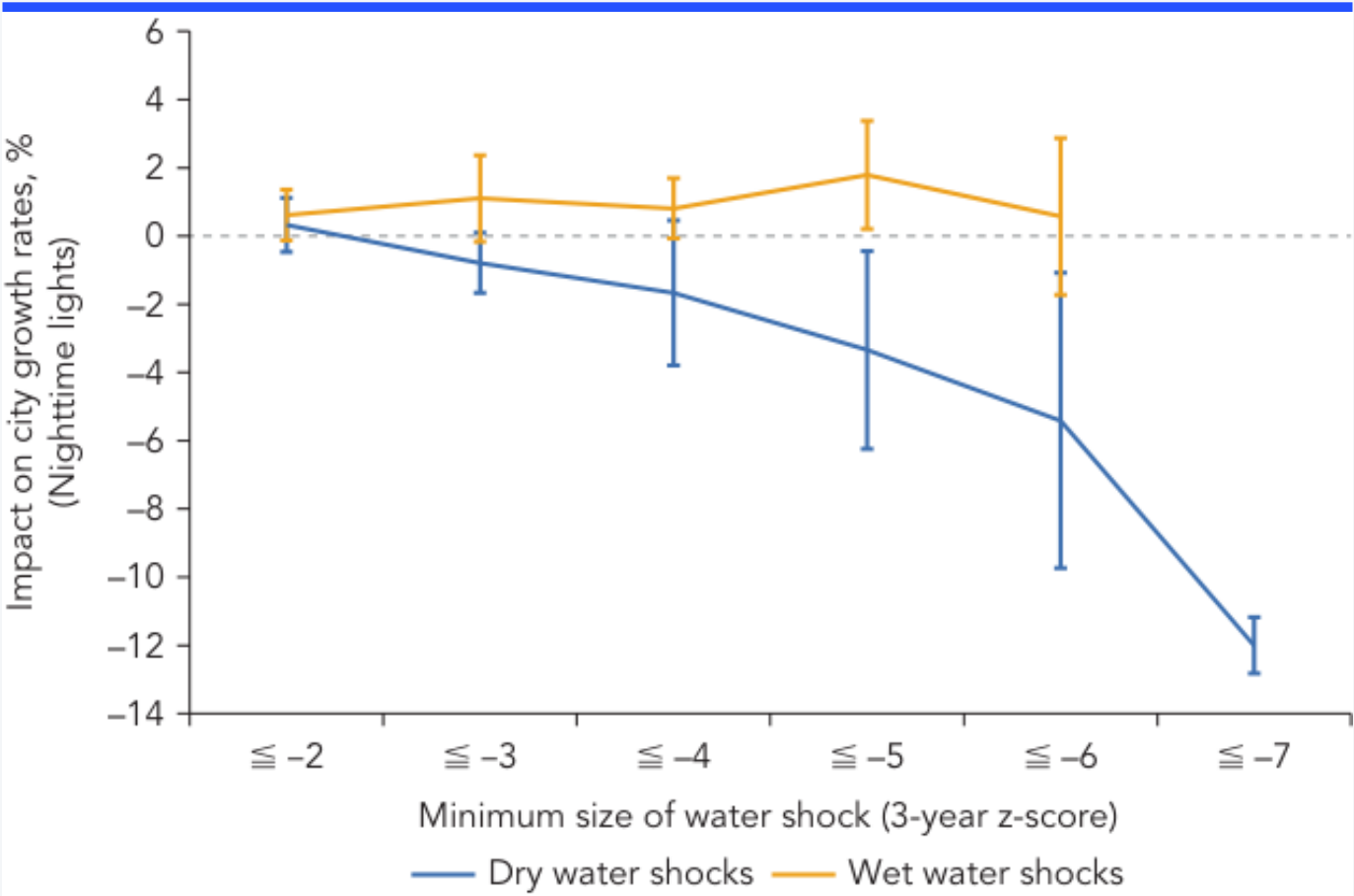


Exhibit. FIGURE 4.1: Impact of Water Supply Shocks on City Growth Rates 6 4 2 0 -2 -4 -6 -8 -10 -12 -14 -2 -3 -4 -5 -6 -7 Minimum size of water shock (3-year z-score) Dry water shocks Wet water shocks (Nighttime lights) Impact on. Source: S0019.

Water, food insecurity, and compounding climate pressures

Climate does not create migration from nothing. It works through the drivers already described — wages, demography, networks — degrading the resource base on which livelihoods rest until staying becomes untenable or leaving becomes the only viable adaptation. The Foresight Report (2011) formalized this as a framework: climate change influences migration decisions *through* existing migration drivers, and understanding the nexus requires four elements — the impacts of climate change on resource quality and availability; the implications for livelihood strategies in particular ecological regions; the role migration itself plays in supporting livelihoods; and how migration patterns shift as people attempt to adapt.⁷

Water and food are the two most direct channels. The World Development Report frames the stakes as “climate change: new risks of distressed movements”: warming already around 1°C above preindustrial levels, likely reaching 1.5°C between 2030 and 2050, brings both more frequent and severe extreme weather and slow-onset deterioration — shifting temperature and precipitation patterns, sea-level rise, ocean warming — with documented effects on health, income, food security, water supply, and human security for roughly 40 percent of the world’s population.²

The analytical geography of climate migration reflects where these pressures bite hardest. Modeling work groups its analysis across regions including the Lower Mekong, South Asia (India and Bangladesh), Central Asia, East Africa, Southern Africa, the Democratic Republic of Congo, West Africa, and Central America and Mexico — areas where rain-fed agriculture, coastal exposure, or water stress concentrate vulnerability.⁵

Three features make water and food insecurity distinctive as migration drivers. First, they are *compounding*: drought reduces yields, which reduces income, which erodes the savings needed to finance either adaptation or migration — the poorest are often the least able to move, producing “trapped” populations rather than flows. Second, they are *gradual*: slow-onset change like aquifer depletion or soil salinization blurs the line between economic and environmental migration, which is why the Foresight framework insists on tracing climate through existing drivers rather than treating it as separate. Third, they are *reversible only at great cost*: once agricultural livelihoods collapse or aquifers run dry, return becomes unlikely even if rainfall recovers.⁷

The decision to migrate under these pressures is genuinely complex — influencing factors change over time and vary across individuals and households, and climate change adds complexity to an already difficult decision. Migration can itself be an adaptation strategy: remittances diversify household income against climate shocks, and seasonal movement has long buffered agrarian societies against bad years.⁷

For the 200-year forecast, the direction is unambiguous but the magnitude is not. Warming trajectories guarantee intensifying pressure on water and food systems across the modeled regions; whether that pressure becomes internal displacement, cross-border movement, or adaptation in place depends on development pathways, conflict dynamics, and — as ever — whether legal channels exist to absorb it.

Conflict, violence, and disaster displacement

Forced displacement is the fastest-growing and most concentrated category of human movement — and the clearest test of whether the migration crisis worsens over the next two centuries.

The numbers are stark and accelerating. An estimated 117.3 million people were forcibly displaced at the end of 2023 — a rise of 8 percent (8.8 million) over 2022, continuing twelve years of year-on-year increases. By the end of 2024, the total reached a record 123.2 million, up another 7 million (6 percent): one in every 67 people on earth. A decade ago, the ratio was one in 125. The number has nearly doubled in ten years, though the rate of increase slowed in the second half of 2024. The refugee population alone grew 7 percent to 43.4 million in 2023, driven substantially by new displacement from Sudan.⁸⁹

Displacement is concentrated in a handful of crises. Slightly more than one-third of all forcibly displaced people in 2024 were Sudanese (14.3 million), Syrian (13.5 million), Afghan (10.3 million), or Ukrainian (8.8 million). And most displaced people never cross a border: internally displaced persons grew 10 percent to 63.3 million at end-2023 — a seventh consecutive annual rise — with more than 80 percent reported in just 10 of the 37 countries where UNHCR works with IDPs, led by Sudan (9.1 million), Syria (7.2 million), Colombia (6.9 million), the Democratic Republic of the Congo (6.3 million), and Yemen (4.5 million). During 2024 alone, an estimated 20.1 million people were displaced within their own countries and 5.4 million as refugees and asylum-seekers.⁹⁸

The newest data add a compounding dimension: conflict and disaster are increasingly striking together. IDMC’s 2026 Global Report on Internal Displacement notes the increase in countries reporting *both* conflict and disaster displacement, underscoring the complexity of internal displacement and the need for resilience in fragile and conflict-affected countries — South Sudan’s communities, forced to move repeatedly by escalating violence and seasonal floods, are emblematic. The same compounding appears in Myanmar and Thailand’s 2025 displacements and in eastern DRC, where violence forces families to flee multiple times.⁴

Solutions are not keeping pace with the stock. In 2023, 6.1 million displaced people returned to their areas or countries of origin (5.1 million IDPs, over 1 million refugees), but only 158,700 refugees were resettled and 32,200 stateless people acquired citizenship. Returns dominate outcomes by volume; resettlement remains a rounding error.⁸

For the 200-year forecast, the trajectory is the report’s central warning: forced displacement has roughly doubled in a decade, is concentrated in a few protracted crises, and is now compounding with climate shocks. Whether the coming century sees 200 million forcibly displaced or a stabilization depends less on demography than on conflict resolution and the absorptive capacity of protection systems — subjects the governance sections will take up.

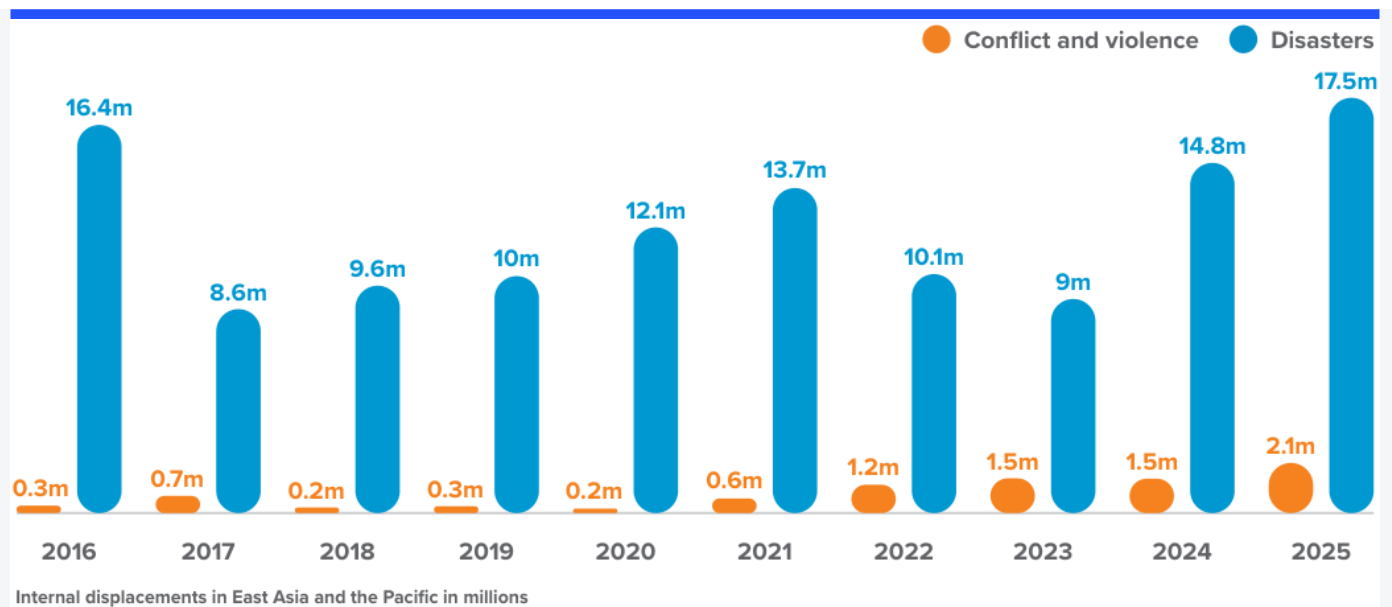


Exhibit. Record numbers of conflict and disaster displacements Disasters Conflict and violence 17.5m 16.4m 14.8m 13.7m 12.1m 10m 10.1m 9.6m 9m 8.6m 2.1m 1.2m 1.5m 1.5m 0.3m 0.7m 0.2m 0.3m 0.2m 0.6m 2016 2017 2018 2019 2020 2021 2022 2023 2024 2025 2. Source: S0029.

Data, methods, and the 200-year forecast

Data sources and measurement challenges

Every forecast in this report rests on data that is thinner than the confidence of its users. Migration is one of the most politically salient topics in the world, yet it remains among the least well measured — a gap that itself shapes policy and constrains foresight.

The data landscape is characterized by divergences and inconsistencies in definitions, collection methodologies, and dissemination strategies. Available data have large gaps across countries and over time, stemming from irregular collection efforts, lack of harmonization, and failures in dissemination — and many datasets, including administrative data collected by governments, remain beyond the reach of academics and policymakers. The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration recognized this by making its very first objective the collection and use of “accurate and disaggregated data as a basis for evidence-based policies”.²

No single instrument suffices. Multiple sources each have strengths and limitations, and effective policymaking requires combining them across geographic, disciplinary, and institutional boundaries so that a comprehensive picture emerges over time. Population censuses remain the primary data sources on global migration: their extensive coverage and granularity enable measurement of long-term movements, and because they are conducted in almost every country at all income levels, they allow some comparability across countries. But censuses are decadal snapshots — blind to circularity, seasonality, and the fast-moving crises that define contemporary displacement.⁴

The margins of the data are revealing in themselves. Even in major monitoring efforts, data are listed for 197 countries while aggregates quietly absorb 4.6 million international migrants in unlisted countries or areas, 9.8 million migrants of unspecified origin, and 99,000 internally displaced persons in unlisted countries. When nearly ten million migrants cannot be assigned an origin, the map has holes exactly where the pressures are greatest.¹⁰

These measurement problems compound the forecast challenge. The Human Development Report’s three findings still frame the analytical task: movement largely reflects people’s need to improve livelihoods; it is constrained by policy and economic barriers that are far harder for poor people to surmount than for the wealthy; and the pressure for increased flows will grow in the coming decades as economic and demographic trends diverge — with the decisive variable being the stance of policymakers, especially in host countries. That stance is itself shaped by data: policymakers who cannot see flows clearly are likelier to govern by anecdote.⁵

For the 200-year forecast, the measurement challenge cuts two ways. On one hand, data gaps make long-range projection speculative — corridor-level flows, irregular movement, and climate displacement are the least measured and the most forecast-relevant. On the other, the direction of pressure is robust to the gaps: divergent demography and persistent wage gaps will grow the pressure for movement regardless of how precisely we count it. Better data would change the shape of the response, not the sign of the trend.

Figure 2.3

... but they also move less

Emigration rates by HDI and income

Panel A: Median emigration rates by origin country HDI group

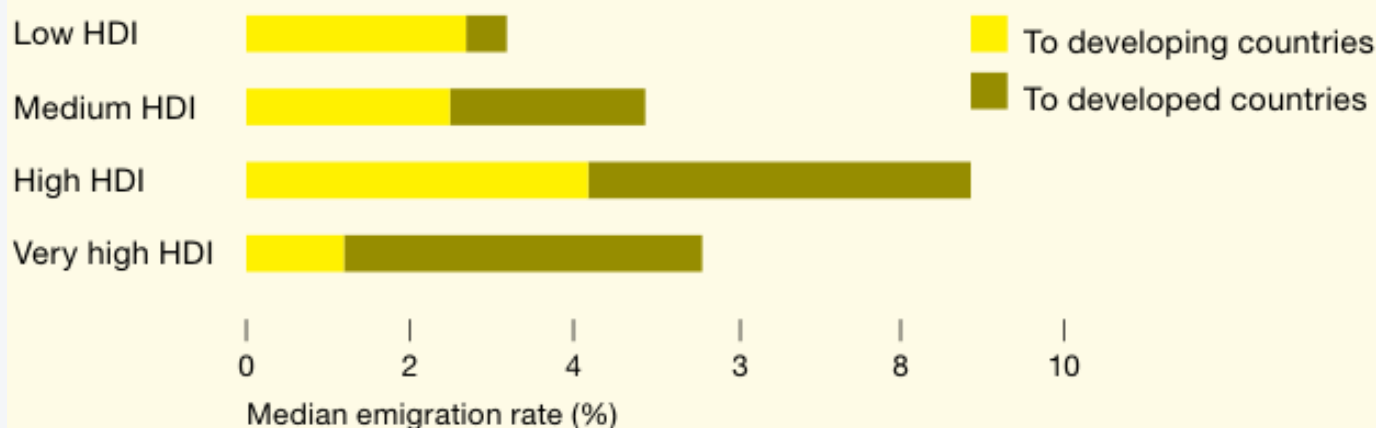


Exhibit. Figure 2.3 ... but they also move less Emigration rates by HDI and income Panel A: Median emigration rates by origin country HDI group Low HDI To developing countries Medium HDI To developed countries High HDI Very high HDI 0 2 4 3 8 10. Source: S0022.

Forecasting methods and their limits

Projecting migration to 2226 — or even 2050 — requires methods honest about what they can and cannot do. The toolkit has three main components, each with characteristic strengths and blind spots.

The most robust component is demographic projection. Population age structures evolve slowly and predictably: the coming competition for workers, driven by aging destinations and youthful origins, can be projected decades ahead with reasonable confidence because the people who will be 25 in 2050 are already born. This is the firmest ground under any long-range migration forecast.

The second component is economic modeling of incentives — wage gaps, labor-market tightness, the migration hump. Here the record is mixed. Movements follow medium-term economic and demographic patterns, but they respond dynamically to policy: transit corridors are highly dynamic, shifting in response to legal restrictions and border controls in transit and destination countries, with the longest corridors leading to high-income countries. A forecast that projects flows without modeling policy responses will be wrong in the details, because the routes themselves adapt.²

The third component is scenario modeling of climate displacement, exemplified by the World Bank's Groundswell work. In its pessimistic reference scenario, South Asia is projected to have 35.7 million internal climate migrants by 2050 (1.6 percent of the total population, ensemble average), reflecting high vulnerability in coastal and deltaic areas facing sea-level rise and storm surges; Bangladesh alone drives 13.3 million — 37 percent of the region's total — and climate migration there could outpace all other internal migrations by 2050. But the same modeling shows outcomes are policy-sensitive: in a more inclusive development scenario, the regional ensemble average is cut by roughly 40 percent. Model choice itself moves results substantially — alternative model combinations under RCP8.5 produce markedly different shares (for example, 11.32 percent versus 15.37 percent in one subregional comparison), illustrating how sensitive projections are to assumptions about crops, water, and climate physics.⁵

Development is the great moderating variable across all methods. Over time, development can reduce the need for distressed movements by strengthening resilience and the ability to absorb shocks, enhancing migrants' skills and their match with destination needs, and improving origin conditions — reducing the need for desperate journeys. Whether the inclusive or the pessimistic scenario materializes is thus partly a function of the development pathways this report examines later.²

The limits are worth stating plainly. Conflict — the largest single driver of forced displacement, with 35.3 million refugees at end-2022 and the largest yearly increase on record driven by Ukraine — is essentially unforecastable. Gender composition shifts, like the striking imbalance of migrant workers in Southern Asia (5.7 million males versus 1.4 million females) and the Arab States (19.9 million versus 4.2 million), can reshape corridors in ways models miss. And over a 200-year horizon, the methods degrade gracefully into scenarios: useful for bounding possibilities, useless for point estimates.¹

The honest use of forecasting is therefore comparative, not predictive — distinguishing which futures are structurally likely (demographic pull, persistent wage gaps) from which are contingent (conflict trajectories, policy architectures), and showing how development pathways widen or narrow the range.

Scenario framework for migration to 2226

A 200-year forecast cannot be a prediction. It can be a structured exploration of how the drivers established in earlier sections combine under different conditions. This section sets out the scenario framework the rest of the report uses: three futures distinguished by two axes — development pathways in origin regions, and the policy architectures of destination states.

Scenario A: Managed mobility. Development is broadly inclusive, cutting distressed movement substantially — the Groundswell modeling shows inclusive development can cut projected climate migration by roughly 40 percent relative to pessimistic baselines. Destination countries, facing the “coming competition for workers,” expand regular pathways; temporary and circular channels absorb much of the demographic pull. Irregular flows shrink because legal alternatives exist. This is the world in which regularization’s demonstrated scale — over 6 million applications in Europe in a decade, 80 percent approved — becomes systematic rather than episodic.⁵

Scenario B: Fortress fragmentation. Destination states respond to demographic pull with restriction rather than absorption. The precedents are visible now: Chile’s once-welcoming approach to immigrants cooling as numbers rise; Denmark tightening asylum policy; Kazakhstan imposing visa limits on Russians fleeing war duty. States increasingly instrumentalize migrants as geopolitical leverage — as when Lithuania and the EU accused Belarus of using refugees as a “political weapon” in 2021. In this scenario, corridors don’t close; they reroute and go underground. Smuggling economies expand, transit states bear the pressure, and the mismatch between labor demand and legal supply widens — aging societies like Bulgaria’s, whose population dived more than 11 percent in a decade, face the sharpest version of the contradiction.⁴

Scenario C: Compound crisis. Climate impacts arrive at the severe end while development stalls and conflicts multiply. Displacement compounds — more countries reporting both conflict and disaster displacement simultaneously — and protection systems built for single-crisis episodes are overwhelmed. Returns and resettlement, already dwarfed by new displacement, fall further behind. This is the trajectory implied if the doubling of forced displacement per decade continues without the conflict resolution or absorptive capacity that earlier sections identified as the key variables.

The framework’s analytical value is comparative. The structural drivers — demographic divergence, wage gaps, network effects — push toward more movement in all three scenarios; what differs is the *form* movement takes and the *human cost* of the journey. Development pathways determine the volume of distressed movement; policy architectures determine whether it flows through airports or across deserts. The remaining sections of the report evaluate specific domains — labor migration, asylum, borders, governance, development — against this framework, asking in each case which scenario current trends favor and what would shift the odds.

Key uncertainties: climate, demography, policy

The scenario framework rests on three pillars, each uncertain in a different way. Understanding the *kind* of uncertainty in each is what separates a useful long-range forecast from a decorative one.

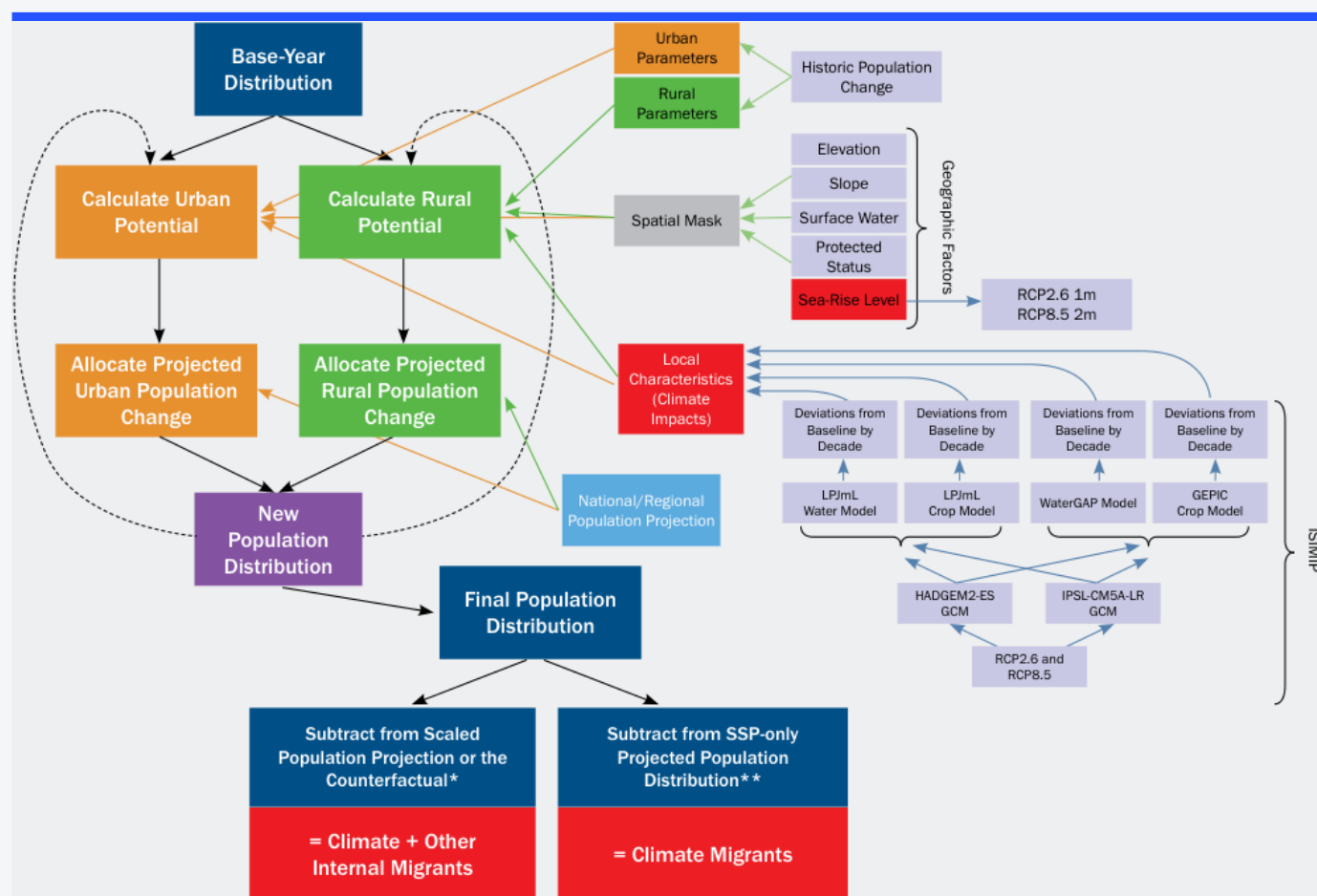
Climate uncertainty is model uncertainty compounded by emissions uncertainty. The World Bank’s Groundswell modeling — the most ambitious attempt to project climate-driven population shifts — illustrates the scale of the apparatus required: feeding all potential ISIMIP water and crop model outputs into its gravity model would yield 12,500 model runs (2 RCPs × 5 GCMs × 25 crop model outputs × 50 water model outputs). The methodology introduces climate-impact projections — water availability, crop productivity, and sea-level rise augmented by storm surge — into a model of future population distribution across six World Bank regions. Sea-level rise alone is augmented with storm-surge increments of 0.85–0.9 meters under RCP 2.6 and 1.68–1.85 meters under RCP 8.5. Crop yields are tracked at 0.5° grid resolution for maize, wheat, rice, and soybeans, converted to decadal averages and indexed against 40-year baselines.⁵

But parameterization itself moves the results. The model was calibrated against actual population changes and actual climate impacts for 1990–2000 and 2000–2010, using two different model combinations (LPJmL for water and crops; WaterGAP for water with GEPIC for crops) — and where the parameter estimates from different combinations diverge, the uncertainty around the ensemble mean grows. This is honest science: the projections carry quantified uncertainty, and the uncertainty is itself informative about which regions’ futures are most assumption-dependent.⁵

Demographic uncertainty is narrower but not negligible. The age structures that drive the competition for workers are largely baked in, but fertility trajectories, mortality shocks, and the pace of urbanization can all shift the numbers at the margin. The modeling covers regions with contrasting climatic, livelihood, demographic, migration, and development patterns — East Africa, South Asia, Mexico and Central America — precisely because the demographic baseline interacts with climate vulnerability.⁷

Policy uncertainty is the widest of the three. Development scenarios (the SSPs) feed directly into the gravity model alongside climate impacts, altering the population potential of every location — and the Groundswell results show the inclusive-development pathway cutting projected climate migration by roughly 40 percent. Corridors adapt dynamically to border controls, so the same pressure produces different geographies under different policies.⁵

For the 200-year horizon, the implication is a hierarchy of confidence: demographic pull is the near-certain backbone; climate impacts are the quantified but wide-ranging amplifier; and policy — the human choice — is both the largest uncertainty and the only one we can deliberately shape.



Note: Boxes in red represent the addition of climate change impacts into the modeling framework or results that reflect climate change impacts.

* The counterfactual population projection simply scales the population distribution in 2010 to country-level population totals appropriate to each SSP.

** The SSP-only population projection represents the population projection without climate change impacts (i.e. based only on the development trajectories embodied in the SSPs).

Exhibit. Figure B.5: Flowchart of modeling steps Urban Base-Year Parameters Historic Population Distribution Rural Change Parameters Elevation Slope Calculate Urban Calculate Rural Potential Potential Spatial Mask Surface Water Protected Sta. Source: S0005.

Forced displacement at record scale

Global forced displacement trends

The aggregate totals tell one story; the composition tells another. Forced displacement is increasingly a story of children, of disasters compounding conflict, and of solutions systems that cannot keep pace.

Children are bearing a disproportionate and growing share. UNICEF’s analysis of weather-related child displacement shows East Asia and the Pacific recording the most child displacements in absolute numbers over the past six years, followed by South Asia — with the Philippines alone accounting for 9.7 million. In relative terms, the picture is more alarming still: East African countries have been most severely affected by floods relative to child population, with South Sudan and Somalia recording flood-driven child displacements equivalent to 11.8 percent and 10.7 percent of their child populations. In small island states the ratios are extreme: Dominica’s weather-related child displacements over six years equal 76 percent of its child population — with the caveat that some children were displaced multiple times.¹¹

The August 2022 Pakistan floods illustrate the compounding at scale: waters covered nearly one-third of the country, caused billions of dollars in damage to crops and housing, and severely affected 33 million people, many displaced — with especially horrific consequences for children left without safe drinking water in unsanitary conditions. On another continent, floods affected more than 280,000 people in Sudan the same year. Drought works more slowly but no less destructively: Hibo, ten years old, fled years of drought in Somalia with her family,

taking ten days to reach an IDP camp — a case for which migration-as-adaptation, with the right information and skills, may be the best available option for young people whose livelihoods are becoming untenable.¹¹

The solutions architecture is constricting even as needs grow. For Myanmar’s refugees, around 31,900 were considered for resettlement in 2024 (including more than 19,500 Rohingya), and just over 10,100 departed — a 47 percent increase from 2023, but overwhelmingly to a single destination (over three-quarters to the United States), with another 1,790 on complementary pathways. Third-country solutions through resettlement are expected to decrease in 2025. The pattern generalizes: returns dominate durable outcomes by volume while resettlement remains a rounding error.⁹

One bright spot is measurement itself. UNHCR’s Forced Displacement Survey is building nationally representative, multi-topic household surveys for low- and lower-middle-income refugee-hosting countries — standardized, internationally comparable socioeconomic data on refugees, asylum-seekers, and host communities, published through UNHCR’s Microdata Library. Better data will not reduce displacement, but it is a precondition for policies that do.⁸

For the forecast, the trend lines point in one direction: displacement that is more youthful, more disaster-compounded, and less solvable through existing channels — the empirical basis for the compound-crisis scenario.

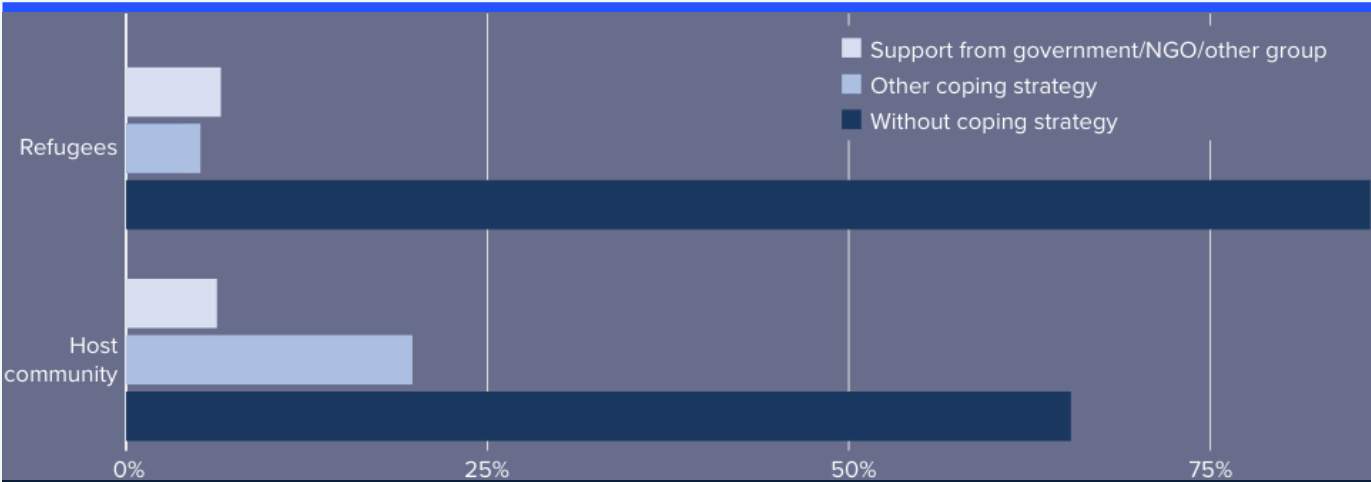


Exhibit. Figure 3 Households’ strategies for coping with the shocks experienced in the north of South Sudan 2022 - 2023 Support from government/NGO/other group Other coping strategy Without coping strategy Refugees Host community 0% 25% 50% 75%. Source: S0003.

Refugees: key situations and demographic composition

Refugee numbers remain at historic highs even as their composition shifts. The global refugee population decreased slightly in 2024 — down 613,600 (–1 percent) to 42.7 million — comprising 31 million refugees under UNHCR’s mandate, 5.9 million other people in need of international protection, and 5.9 million Palestine refugees under UNRWA. The decrease reflects lower estimates of Afghan refugees, fewer Syrian refugees, and updated reporting of Ukrainians — revisions to estimates, not resolutions of crises. This follows the largest yearly increase on record between 2021 and 2022, driven by Ukraine, and a mid-2022 total of about 37.8 million refugees worldwide. The refugee population has more than doubled over the last decade.^{9,12}

The key situations are familiar and protracted. Afghans, Syrians, and Ukrainians remain among the largest refugee populations, joined by the Sudanese displaced by the 2023 conflict and the Rohingya — for whom third-country resettlement is expected to decrease in 2025 even as needs persist. What distinguishes the current moment is not a new crisis but the accumulation: crises that do not end, each adding to a stock that solutions systems cannot drain.⁹

The demographic composition of forced and labor migrants alike skews toward prime working age. Across all income levels, the prime-age group (25–54) dominates among international migrants in the labor force — in 2022 accounting for 76.2 percent of men and 74.6 percent of women in high-income destination countries. Young men (15–24) are most prominent in low-income destinations at 15.5 percent, with the share falling as destination income rises. Migrants participate in labor markets at higher rates than non-migrants globally (65.8 percent versus 60.1 percent), though migrant women’s participation (52.8 percent) lags migrant men’s, and women constitute 38.7 percent of international migrants in the labor force against men’s 61.3 percent.¹²

The demographic backdrop is diverging sharply. Low-income countries are in the throes of an ongoing demographic explosion — Niger being the emblematic case — while in high-income countries the elderly population is growing and the working-age population declining; by 2050, high-income OECD countries will have fewer than two working-age individuals supporting every elderly person. By 2050, Sub-Saharan

Africa will be the only region still experiencing population growth — the same region whose large numbers of unemployed and underemployed youth have, for the most part, skills not yet matched to global labor-market demand.²

Climate exposure overlays this demography. More than 1 billion people live in low-lying cities and settlements at risk from coastal climate impacts by 2050; the global sea level has already risen 0.20 meters since 1900 with acceleration since the late 1960s, and US\$7–14 trillion in coastal infrastructure assets could be at risk by 2100 — with large coastal areas across South and Southeast Asia, urban and rural, already exposed.²

For the forecast, the composition matters as much as the count: refugee populations that are young, growing, and increasingly exposed to coastal and climate risks — while residing disproportionately in the low-income regions with the least capacity to absorb them.

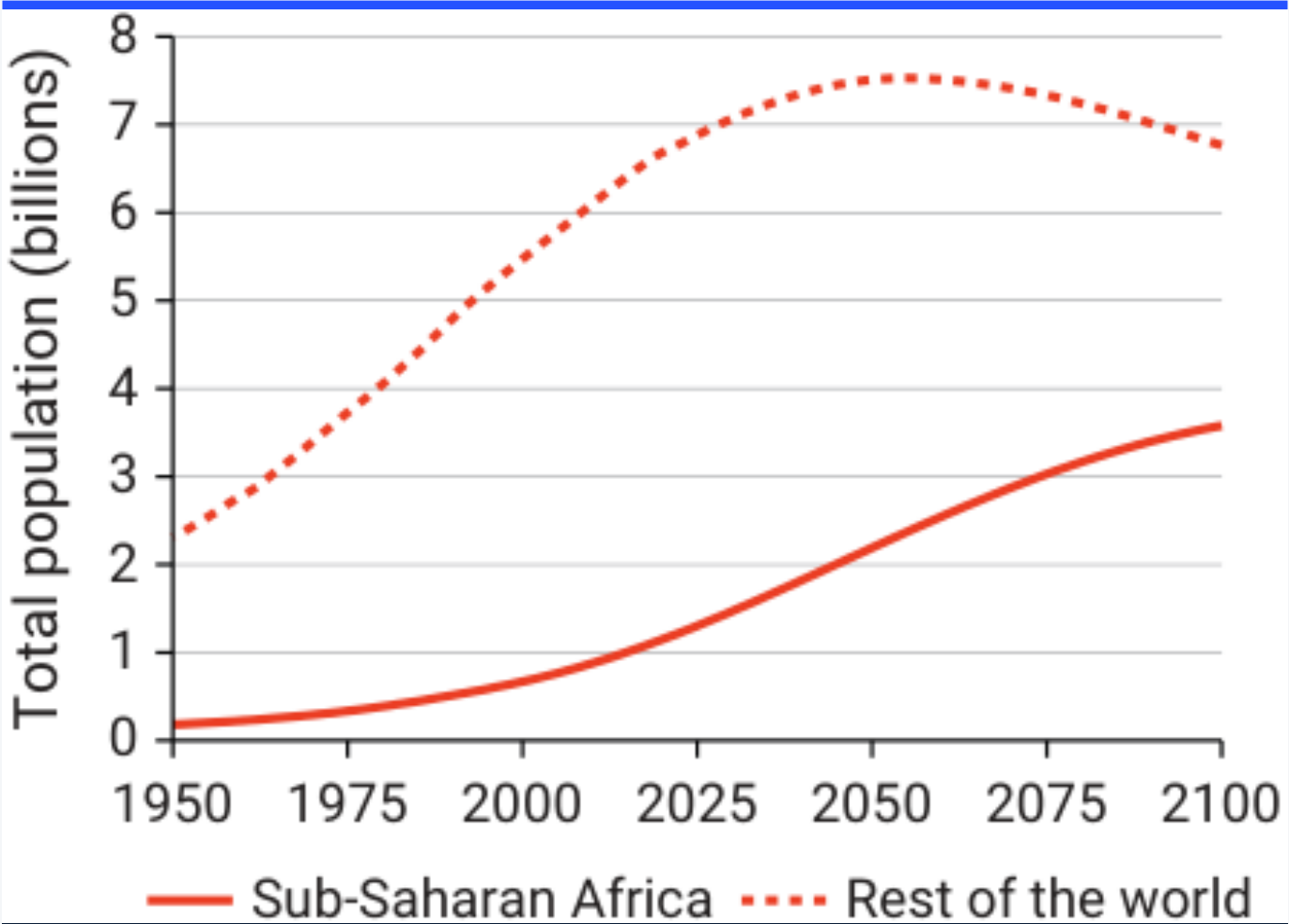


Exhibit. Figure 3.9 By 2050, Sub-Saharan Africa will be the only region with population growth 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1 0 1950 1975 2000 2025 2050 2075 2100 Sub-Saharan Africa Rest of the world Total population (billions). Source: S0010.

Internally displaced people (IDPs): scale, drivers, and returns

Internal displacement is the largest and least visible component of forced movement — people uprooted who never cross a border and therefore never enter refugee statistics. The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre tracks it as two distinct measures: new displacements during a given period, and the total stock of IDPs at a point in time, categorized by two broad causes — disasters, and conflict and violence.¹

The stock figures are at record levels. An estimated 62.5 million people were internally displaced by conflict and violence across 65 countries and territories as of 31 December 2022 — the highest since IDMC began monitoring in 1998. UNHCR’s own reporting, covering 38 countries, put the end-2024 figure at 68.1 million people internally displaced by armed conflicts, generalized violence, or human rights violations. And the flow continues: over 20.1 million new internal displacements were reported worldwide in 2024, some 13.5 million of them in countries where UNHCR works — concentrated in just six: the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Haiti, Lebanon, Myanmar, Sudan, and Ukraine.¹⁹

The driver distinction is blurring. IDMC acknowledges the growing difficulty of separating disasters from conflict as the immediate cause of displacement, and the need for better ways to report on displacement driven by multiple causes. South Sudan’s communities — moving repeatedly under the combined pressure of escalating violence and seasonal floods — are the emblematic case. In Africa, where conflict-

related IDPs exceeded 12 million as early as 2015 (led then by Sudan at 3.2 million, Nigeria 2.1 million, South Sudan 1.7 million, and the DRC 1.5 million), the pattern of repeated displacement compounds the dangers, especially for children.¹⁴¹⁰

Returns are the main exit from internal displacement — and they are fragile. The 6.1 million returns in 2023 (5.1 million IDPs) established earlier in this report represent the largest durable-solution channel by far, but returns to insecure or disaster-damaged areas often mean displacement deferred rather than ended: families in eastern DRC are being helped to return home even as violence forces others to flee multiple times. Nearly 90 percent of Asia’s refugees find asylum elsewhere in Asia, and the same proximity logic governs IDP returns — people go home when home is close, not when it is safe.⁴¹⁰

For the forecast, internal displacement is the category most likely to grow fastest: it absorbs the compound-crisis scenario’s compound shocks first, it is the least covered by international protection frameworks, and its drivers — protracted conflict plus intensifying disasters — are the ones trending most unfavorably. Any serious 200-year migration outlook must treat IDP trends as the leading indicator, not the footnote.

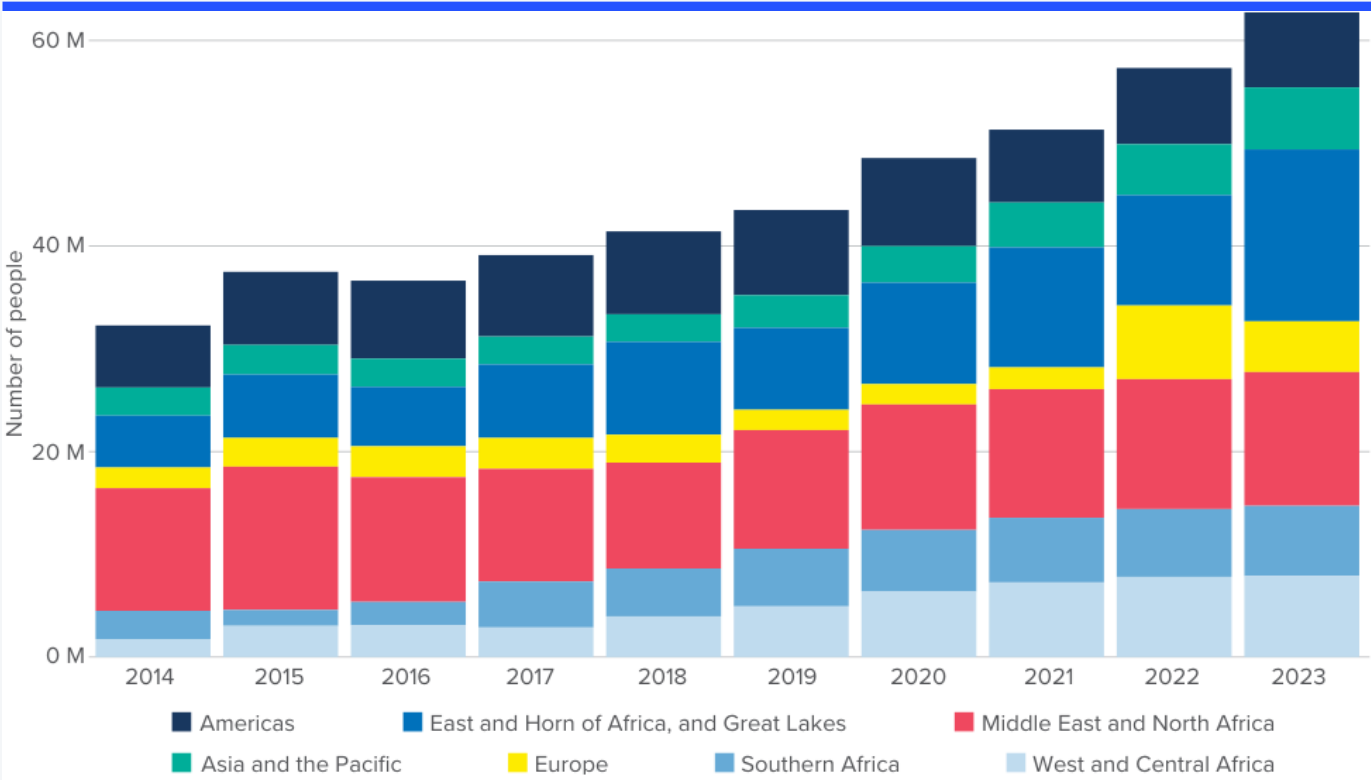


Exhibit. Figure 11 IDPs protected/assisted by UNHCR by region 2014 – 2023 60 M 40 M 20 M 0 M 2014 2015 2016 2017 2018 2019 2020 2021 2022 2023 Americas East and Horn of Africa, and Great Lakes Middle East and North Africa Asia and the Paci. Source: S0003.

Stateless people

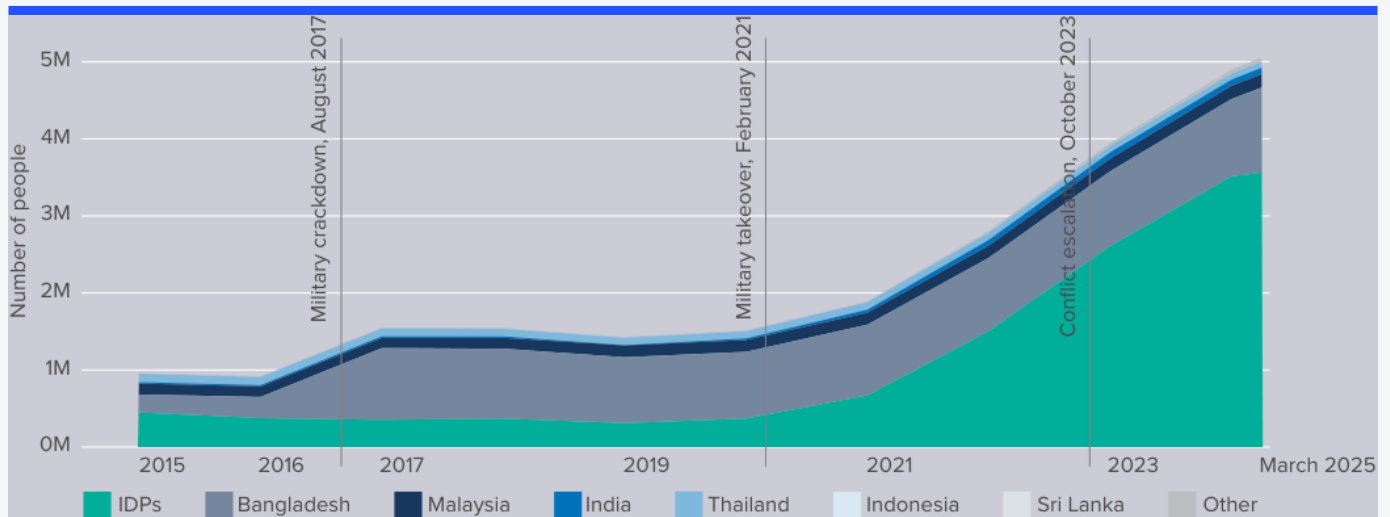
Statelessness is the quietest crisis in the displacement system — people denied a nationality by any state, and with it the documents, rights, and mobility that citizenship confers. It is both a cause and a consequence of forced movement: stateless populations are among the most vulnerable to displacement, and displacement in turn strips people of the papers that prove who they are.

The Rohingya are the emblematic case. In 2017, 655,500 Rohingya fled military crackdowns in Rakhine State and sought refuge in Bangladesh; since then, escalating conflict and human rights violations have displaced millions more within Myanmar and to neighboring countries. As of March 2025, Myanmar’s crisis counted 3.6 million people displaced internally and 1.5 million refugees and asylum-seekers abroad — a population whose statelessness predates and compounds their displacement. Efforts to address it focus on the unglamorous infrastructure of identity: birth registration and civil status documentation, supported through regional cooperation.⁹

Resolution, where it happens, is incremental. In 2023, 32,200 stateless people had their nationality confirmed or acquired citizenship — a meaningful number of individual lives, and a rounding error against the scale of statelessness worldwide.⁸

Statelessness also interacts with the newest displacements. The Gaza conflict since October 2023 uprooted 90 percent of the entire civilian population, most displaced multiple times, with 2 million remaining internally displaced at end-2024; a January 2025 ceasefire brought brief relief before conflict resumed in March 2025. In Lebanon, the September 2024 escalation displaced nearly a million people within the country (984,500) at the height of the crisis. In protracted displacement, documentation is lost, births go unregistered, and statelessness reproduces itself across generations.⁹

For the forecast, statelessness is a slow-moving multiplier: it does not generate the headlines of new wars, but it ensures that the displaced remain displaced — unable to naturalize, to travel legally, or to pass secure status to their children. Any long-range outlook that counts refugees without counting the stateless understates both the stock of vulnerability and the difficulty of durable solutions.



Humanitarian needs have grown since the military takeover in February 2021. They have escalated further after an intensification of the conflict and a surge in violence in late 2023, including in Rakhine

State. The deteriorating situation has placed additional strains on local communities and already overstretched services and facilities. Civilians continue to face grave violations and risks amid the

Exhibit. Figure 5 Number of IDPs in Myanmar and refugees and asylum-seekers from Myanmar 2015 – March 2025 5M 4M 3M 2M 1M 0M 2015 2016 2017 2019 2021 2023 March 2025 IDPs Bangladesh Malaysia India Thailand Indonesia Sri Lanka Other Humani. Source: S0004.

Children on the move

Children are the fastest-growing and most vulnerable category of movers — and the one for which protection systems are least adequate. Their journeys concentrate every risk in the migration system: violence, exploitation, deprivation, and the loss of schooling.

The Central Mediterranean route illustrates the scale. In 2024, IOM registered 11,622 vulnerable migrant children on the CMR across Egypt, Libya, Niger, and Tunisia — 14 percent of them unaccompanied and separated (1,580 children), and 3 percent (353) identified as potential victims of human trafficking. The origins have shifted with the crises: from 2020 to 2024, 70 percent of registered migrant children in these transit countries were in Egypt (35,882 children), the vast majority from the recent Sudan influx who cannot return there; Libya accounted for 5 percent (2,506) and Nigeria 4 percent.³

The journey itself is defined by deprivation. Among migrants surveyed in Europe, the biggest reported challenges were financial difficulties (36 percent), hunger (31 percent), and inadequate shelter (26 percent); in Libya, one in five migrants lived in buildings deemed uninhabitable and 89 percent without electricity, with migrant children often sleeping in unsafe conditions. A quarter of migrants in Libya are Nigerien, and 20 percent cite food and water insecurity as their top difficulty.³

Debt is both the financing mechanism and the trap. Seventeen percent of migrant youth took on a debt or loan specifically to fund their journey, and 22 percent planned to repay money to someone on arrival — creating immediate pressure that smugglers and traffickers exploit, with debt used as a method of coercion and control. The trafficking data confirm the pattern: in 2023, 37 girls and 16 boys were verified as trafficking victims exploited on the CMR (alongside 229 women and 434 men); from 2016 to 2023, trafficked children on this route were controlled through abuse (33 percent), threats (27 percent), forced labor (26 percent), denial of basic needs (20 percent), sexual exploitation (14 percent), and debt bondage (10 percent). Girls from Mali, Nigeria, Somalia, and the Central African Republic face significant risks of sexual exploitation and forced child marriage along the route.³

Education is the silent casualty. Families migrate hoping new homes will offer better opportunities, but for forcibly displaced children movement brings added dangers; three long-standing conflicts are exacting a severe toll on schooling, with well over one-third of primary and lower-secondary aged children in South Sudan, Niger, and Sudan out of school. Evidence on the long-term impacts of migration on children remains extremely limited and the effects mixed.¹⁰

The policy response is moving toward a route-based approach: strengthening protection and solutions for refugees and migrants in the context of mixed and onward movements, recognizing that while their rights and the solutions for them are distinct, those using the same routes face similar vulnerabilities and risks. For children, this means protection that travels with them — not systems that wait at borders.⁸

For the forecast, the demographic logic is inexorable: youthful origin regions will keep producing young movers, and without child-specific protection along routes, the human cost will scale with the flows.

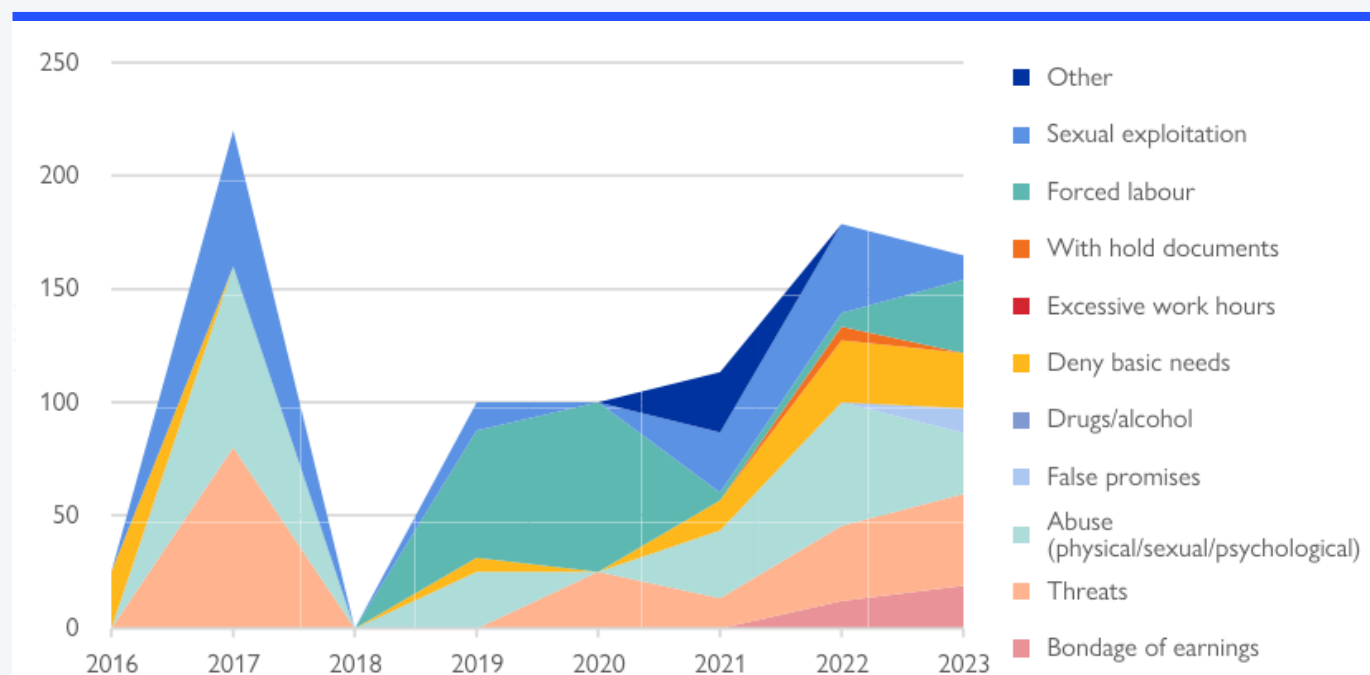


Exhibit. Figure 25. Girl Victims of Trafficking and Types of Exploitation on the CMR by Year (2016–2023) 250 Other Sexual exploitation 200 Forced labour With hold documents 150 Excessive work hours Deny basic needs 100 Drugs/alcohol False p. Source: S0028.

Climate migration: projections and scenarios

State of the art in climate migration modeling

Climate migration modeling has matured from speculative extrapolation to a defined — if still young — methodological field. Two families of models dominate, with complementary strengths.

Gravity models are the workhorse. Derived from Newton’s law of gravity, they replace “bodies” and “masses” with “locations” and “importance,” where importance can be measured in population numbers, GDP, or other attributes. In the Groundswell framework, gravity models reproduce past evolutions of population distributions based on observed agglomeration effects over large geographic regions, under varying conditions and at alternative spatial scales, and can be refined to incorporate additional factors — notably climate impacts on water availability and crop productivity, which alter the population potential of locations within countries. The modeling provides transparent, spatially explicit estimates of changes in population distribution — and indirectly migration — as a function of climate and development trends, with calibration details published and validation conducted using Mexico and Ethiopia.⁵

Radiation models are the newer challenger. They reproduce mobility fluxes using only information on the population distribution — no migration data required — and predict mobility patterns in good agreement with long-term migration patterns between regions. Like gravity models they include a spatial component, so results can be mapped. But they are only beginning to be applied to climate migration and have so far been limited to the sea-level-rise case.⁵

Both approaches share a critical caveat the Groundswell authors stress: it is important to understand what the model does and does not do. What it does is project shifts in population distribution under climate and development scenarios — internal redistribution, not cross-border migration per se. What it does not do is model conflict, policy responses, or the network effects that determine which corridors absorb the displaced. The ensemble apparatus (up to 12,500 possible model runs across RCPs, GCMs, crop and water models) quantifies physical uncertainty; the human variables remain outside the equations.⁵

The frontier is integration: coupling population-distribution models with conflict forecasting, corridor-dynamics models, and policy-response functions. Until that integration exists, climate migration modeling gives us the pressure field — where livelihoods will degrade — while the earlier sections of this report supply the rest: the demography that determines who is exposed, the economics that determine who can move, and the policies that determine where they go.

Shared socioeconomic pathways and scenario combinations

The scenario framework of this report rests on a formal modeling architecture: the combination of Shared Socioeconomic Pathways (SSPs) and Representative Concentration Pathways (RCPs) used in the Groundswell climate-migration projections.

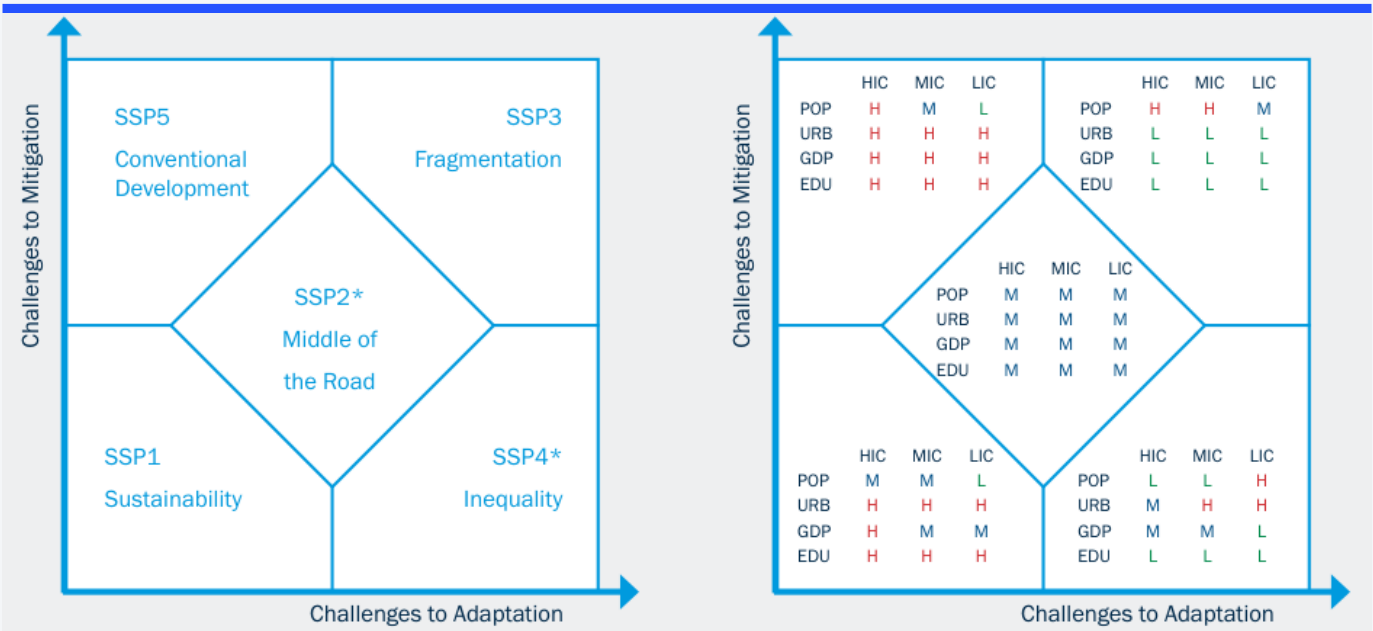
The SSPs describe alternative development futures. SSP2 represents moderate development — middle-of-the-road socioeconomic trends continuing historical patterns. SSP4 represents unequal development — a world of deepening inequality, where elites capture gains while large populations are left behind. These are not predictions but structured “what if” inputs: they parameterize how attractive different locations are in the gravity model, shaping where populations concentrate or thin out.⁵

The RCPs describe alternative emissions futures. RCP2.6 is the low-emissions pathway, consistent with aggressive mitigation; RCP8.5 is the high-emissions pathway, consistent with continued fossil-fuel dependence. They drive the climate impacts on water availability and crop productivity as well as sea-level rise augmented by storm surge that feed the model.⁵

Combined, they produce the scenario matrix: SSP2/RCP2.6 (moderate development, low emissions — the most optimistic), SSP2/RCP8.5, SSP4/RCP2.6, and SSP4/RCP8.5 (unequal development, high emissions — the pessimistic reference). The projections of climate migration are aggregated for all six World Bank regions modeled across both Groundswell reports, giving a global picture of the scale and trend of climate migration to 2050.⁵

The matrix’s lesson for migration is the interaction effect. The worst outcomes come not from climate alone or development alone, but from their combination: unequal development under high emissions concentrates vulnerability exactly where adaptive capacity is weakest. This is the quantitative backbone of the report’s scenario framework — Scenario A (managed mobility) corresponds to the SSP2/RCP2.6 corner, Scenario C (compound crisis) to SSP4/RCP8.5, and the fortress-fragmentation world sits between, where development is uneven and policy responses determine which pressures become movements and which become trapped populations.

For the 200-year horizon, the SSP/RCP matrix cannot be run out mechanically — the pathways were designed for mid-century, not 2226. But its logic endures: the future of migration is the product of two human choices, how we develop and how we emit, and the range between the best and worst combinations is the range this report’s scenarios explore.



Source: Jiang (2014).
Note: H = high, M = medium, L = low, POP = population, URB = urbanization, GDP = gross domestic product, EDU = education, HIC = high income countries, MIC = medium income countries, LIC = low income countries; * = SSPs used in the model for this report.

Exhibit. Figure B.2: Qualitative Shared Socioeconomic Pathway narratives (left) and the underlying assumptions (right) on various indicators for countries by income group HIC MIC LIC HIC MIC LIC SSP5 SSP3 POP H M L POP H H M URB H H H URB L. Source: S0005.

Projected numbers and spatial patterns of climate migrants

The Groundswell projections give the most complete quantitative picture of climate-driven internal migration to 2050 — and the numbers are large under every scenario. Common trends emerge across the modeled regions: internal climate migration increases under all three scenarios in all regions. Under the pessimistic reference scenario — high emissions coupled with unequal development — the number of internal climate migrants could exceed 143 million by 2050 (average 118 million, minimum 92 million), with Sub-Saharan Africa seeing as many as 85.7 million, South Asia 40.5 million, and Latin America 17.1 million.²

The regional patterns reflect distinct vulnerabilities. South Asia’s 35.7 million projected climate migrants by 2050 (1.6 percent of the population, ensemble average) reflect high vulnerability in coastal and deltaic areas facing sea-level rise and storm surges, with Bangladesh driving 13.3 million — 37 percent of the regional total — and climate migration there potentially outpacing all other internal migration by 2050. The subregion’s story is one of continued densification in already very high densities — fastest along the Indus River and the Gangetic Plain, with Delhi, Dhaka, Lahore, and Karachi growing rapidly on rural-to-urban flows — while disasters displace hundreds of thousands yearly, regularly making India one of the countries with the largest disaster-displaced populations, and agricultural dependence makes monsoon variability and failed rains a migration driver.^{5,7}

North Africa is projected at 13.0 million climate migrants by 2050 (6.0 percent of population) in the pessimistic scenario, 9.9 million (4.2 percent) under inclusive development, and 4.5 million (2.1 percent) in the climate-friendly scenario — the scenario differences highlighting how both development pathways and emissions reductions ease pressure on livelihood systems. Central Asia reaches 2.4 million (3.4 percent) pessimistically, with a wide spread (1.1–3.6 million), versus 1.9 million under inclusive development and 1.7 million climate-friendly. One modeled subregion rises from 2.6 million climate migrants in 2020 to an average 10.1 million by 2050 pessimistically (0.6 to 1.3 percent of population), with the Lake Victoria Basin, Ethiopia’s eastern highlands, and the Lilongwe area emerging as in-migration hotspots.^{5,7}

In Mexico and Central America, the mechanism is rainfed agriculture’s fragility: households dependent on it are particularly sensitive to drought and cyclones, forcing family members to seek alternative livelihoods in cities and abroad, against a food system heavily dependent on maize and bean production.²

The through-line: development and emissions choices roughly halve or double the outcomes — the inclusive-development scenario cuts South Asia’s total by about 40 percent — but under no modeled scenario does climate migration decline. For the 200-year forecast, 2050 is only the first waypoint; the spatial pattern it establishes — coasts, deltas, drylands, and rainfed-agriculture zones emptying toward cities and highlands — sets the geography of movement for the century that follows.⁵

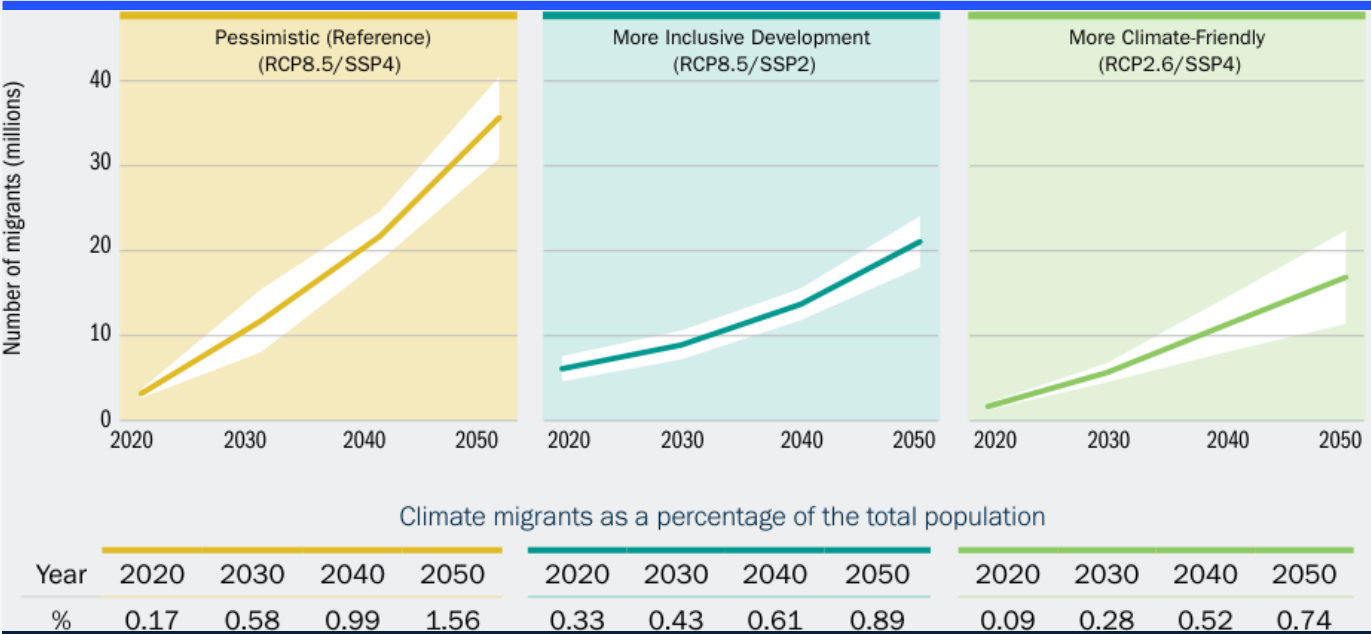


Exhibit. Figure 4.13: Projected number of internal climate migrants in South Asia under three scenarios, 2020–50 Pessimistic (Reference) More Inclusive Development More Climate-Friendly (RCP8. Source: S0006.

Regional hotspots: Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia, Latin America, North Africa

The global aggregates resolve into four regional hotspots where demographic, climatic, and conflict pressures overlap most intensely.

The Middle East and North Africa is the acute crisis zone. MENA recorded 13.7 million internal displacements in 2025 — its highest annual figure on record — accounting for more than 40 percent of all conflict displacements globally. Conflict and violence triggered 13.4

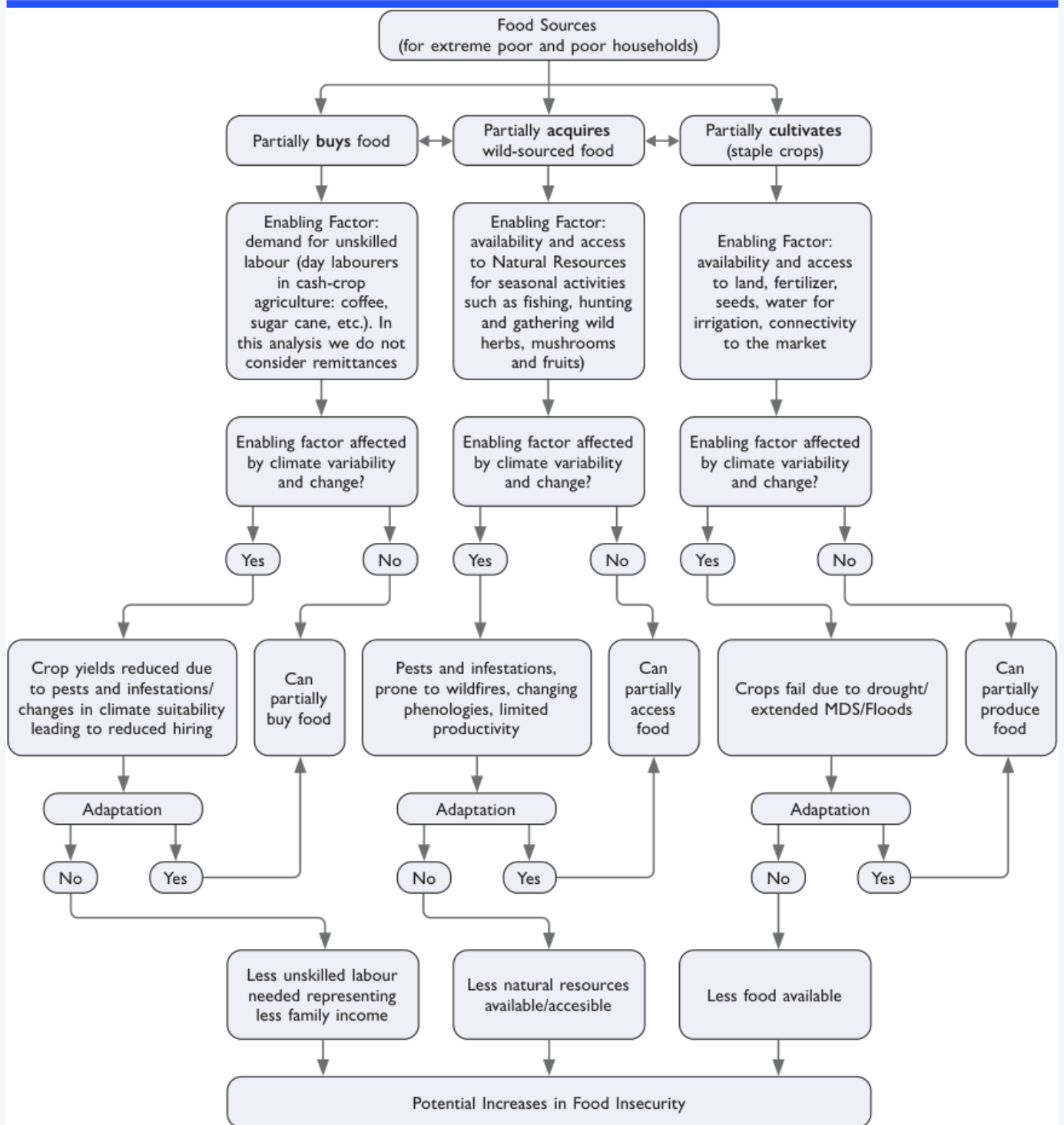
million movements, more than 2.6 times the 2024 figure, which was already the highest on record; the sharp increase resulted from expanding international armed conflict across the region. Disasters accounted for only around 294,000 displacements — less than half the 2024 figure — mostly in Yemen, where floods overlapped with conflict and further constrained humanitarian access. Nearly 14.2 million people remained internally displaced in the region.⁴

Sub-Saharan Africa is the structural pressure zone: the only region still growing in population by 2050, with the largest projected climate-migrant numbers (up to 85.7 million), the worst flood-driven child displacement relative to population, and repeated compound displacement in South Sudan. Its in-migration hotspots — the Lake Victoria Basin, Ethiopia’s eastern highlands, the Lilongwe area — will absorb internal redistribution first.⁷

South Asia combines the densest exposure with the largest absolute numbers: 35.7 million projected climate migrants by 2050 pessimistically, Bangladesh’s 13.3 million, and the Indus–Gangetic densification corridor channeling rural-to-urban flows into Delhi, Dhaka, Lahore, and Karachi.⁵⁷

Latin America is the corridor under fastest transformation. Ecuador has become a new gateway to the Americas, with violence and unemployment driving Ecuadorians toward Mexico. Chile’s once-welcoming approach has cooled as numbers rise. The US Title 42 era ended, but the conditions driving migrants north persist. The region’s 17.1 million projected climate migrants by 2050 will layer onto these existing corridors.¹⁷

The hotspot framing matters for policy: each region needs different instruments — conflict resolution and protection in MENA, development and adaptation in Sub-Saharan Africa, urban absorption in South Asia, and corridor management in the Americas. The 200-year forecast’s geography is these four regions’ trajectories, diverging or converging depending on the scenario.



Source: Pons, 2021.

Exhibit. Appendix B. Pathways of food security for poor and extreme poor farmers in Guatemala Food Sources (for extreme poor and poor households) Partially acquires Partially cultivates Partially buys food wild-sourced food (stap. Source: S0001.

Water and crop models behind the projections

Behind the climate-migration numbers sits a specific machinery: the Inter-Sectoral Impact Model Intercomparison Project (ISIMIP), which couples global climate models with sectoral water and crop models to estimate how livelihoods degrade, grid cell by grid cell.

The model combinations pair general circulation models (HadGEM2-ES, IPSL-CM5A-LR) with water models (LPJmL, WaterGAP2) and crop models (LPJmL, GEPIC) — the four-model combinations whose divergent parameter estimates drive the ensemble uncertainty described earlier. The water sector outputs represent river discharge; the crop sector outputs represent yields for maize, wheat, rice, and soybeans at 0.5° resolution. Converted to decadal averages and indexed against long baselines, they become the “population potential” adjustments in the gravity model: places where water runs short and yields fall become places people leave.²⁵

The demographic inputs matter as much as the climate physics. East Africa’s population of 422 million in 2017 (total fertility rate 4.7, only 27 percent urban) is projected at 786 million under SSP4 or 675 million under SSP2 by 2050; West Africa’s 371 million (TFR 5.3) at 792 or 678

million; Central Africa's 163 million (TFR 5.9, the highest) at 391 or 349 million; South Asia's 1.885 billion at 2.29 or 2.37 billion. The development pathway alone — SSP2 versus SSP4 — moves hundreds of millions of people between scenarios, which is why the inclusive-development future cuts projected climate migration so substantially.²

The regional mechanics illustrate the stakes. Central Asia faces droughts, desertification, floods, glacier retreat, and shifting river flows — but adopting modern agricultural techniques could raise crop yields by over 20 percent by 2030, a concrete adaptation lever. Ethiopia, one of Africa's most climate-vulnerable countries, depends on rainfed agriculture as the dominant livelihood (agriculture accounts for 37 percent of the economy), with droughts linked to El Niño cycles repeatedly causing food shortages. North Africa's water security rests on aquifers beneath a dry interior, with dust storms and extreme heat threatening the margins.⁵⁷

Critically, the 2050 projections may be only the beginning: ISIMIP comparisons of 2050–2100 against 1970–2010 baselines show impacts becoming more severe in the second half of the century, further strengthening the conditions for increased climate migration. For the 200-year forecast, the model machinery covers the first quarter of the journey; beyond that, the direction is set by the physics — more severe, more certain — while the human numbers depend on the adaptation and development choices the models can only parameterize.²

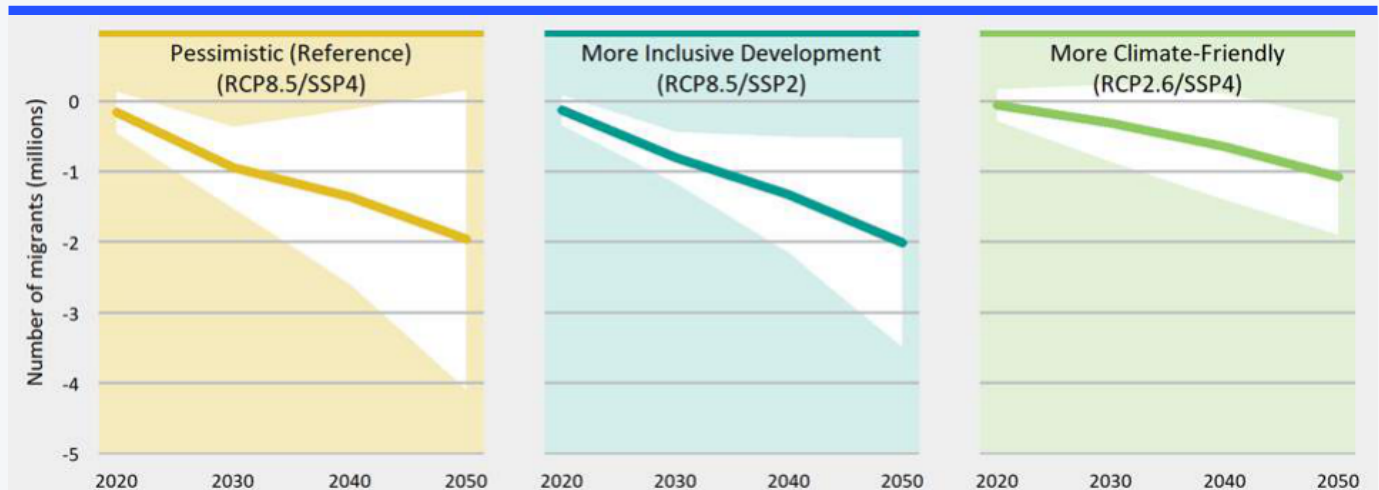


Exhibit. Figure 2.10: Projected net climate migration in and out of coastal zones in North Africa in three scenarios, 2020–2050
Note: Dark lines represent the average runs for each scenario. Source: S0005.

Labor mobility and the economics of migration

Labor mobility partnerships and managed migration corridors

If demography and wage gaps create the pressure for movement, bilateral labor partnerships are the valve that determines whether it flows through managed channels or around them. The World Development Report's framework is direct: because international mobility involves at least two countries, bilateral cooperation manages it effectively — matching countries with surpluses in certain sectors and skill sets with countries facing shortages, structuring mutually beneficial migration through bilateral labor agreements, and enhancing the skills match through recognition and skills development. When the match between migrants' attributes and destination needs is strong, the gains are large — for migrants, origin countries, and destinations alike.²

The alternative is disorganization. Labor migration is often chaotic — driven by individual choices, noneconomic factors, and aggressive brokers steering destination choices away from labor-market needs. Where managed corridors don't exist, the smuggling industry fills the gap: a complex, dynamic, constantly evolving illegal economy in which at least 2.5 million migrants were smuggled in 2016 for US\$5.5–7 billion in returns — roughly equivalent to the entire humanitarian aid budget of the United States or the European Union that year. Smuggling operations range from lone actors and small networks to sophisticated multinational criminal organizations, sometimes loosely linked via social networks, sometimes providing quasi-legal services like taxi transport.²

The concentration of migrant workers makes the partnership case concrete: 102.4 million — almost 61 percent of all international migrant workers — reside in just three subregions: Northern America, the Arab States, and Northern, Southern and Western Europe. Managed corridors in these destinations would cover the majority of global labor migration by volume.¹

Development and partnership are complements, not substitutes. Over time, development reduces the need for distressed movements by strengthening resilience, enhancing migrants' skills and their match with destination needs, and improving origin conditions — but bilateral agreements are what convert today's mismatched flows into tomorrow's managed ones.²

For the 200-year forecast, the question is whether the bilateral-agreement model scales. The fortress-fragmentation scenario is defined by its absence: restriction without partnership, which expands the smuggling economy it claims to fight. The managed-mobility scenario is defined by its spread: a dense web of bilateral and regional labor agreements that absorb demographic pressure through legal channels. The corridor geography of 2226 will be written by whichever logic prevails.

Skills, training, and brain drain

The movement of skilled people is migration's most contested ledger entry: a gain for destinations competing for workers, a potential loss for the origin countries that trained them, and — under the right policies — a net gain for both.

The benefits for origin countries are real and multi-channel. Cross-border mobility can be a powerful force for reducing poverty: remittances, knowledge and technology flows, higher incentives and opportunities for human capital accumulation, and more efficient allocation of labor. Diasporas do more than send money — they integrate origin countries into the global economy and facilitate trade and foreign direct investment, while returning migrants bring back improved skills, assets, and knowledge regardless of their formal education level.²

But the costs are equally real. When a large share of the adult population emigrates — including highly skilled professionals — the losses fall hardest on smaller and poorer countries that can least afford to lose doctors, engineers, and teachers. The impacts of emigration on origin countries are neither preset nor uniform, within or across societies — and crucially, origin countries can shape them. The World Development Report's strategic prescription is to make emigration part of development strategies rather than treating it as a failure of them: in countries with large current or potential labor emigration, policy should manage the outflow for development rather than merely lamenting it.²

The knowledge channel deserves emphasis because it is the most durable. Engaging the emigrant community to encourage knowledge transfers and global integration can invigorate the domestic economy — and much of this happens through individual and private initiative, where governments' best role is maintaining a favorable business environment and easy access to strong institutions rather than directing the flows. Training systems in origin countries can be designed with mobility in mind: building skills that match destination demand (strengthening the “match” from the partnerships framework) while raising domestic human capital whether or not individuals emigrate.²

The intergenerational stakes are visible in displacement too: UNICEF counts 21.2 million child displacements from storm events alone — each one a potential interruption of schooling that compounds into a human-capital loss for origin societies already losing their skilled adults.

[11](#)

For the 200-year forecast, the brain-drain question inverts. As destination countries age and compete for workers, the bargaining power shifts toward origin countries with young, skilled populations. The winners will be the countries that treat emigration as an export industry to be managed — training for global demand, capturing remittances and knowledge flows, and building return pathways — rather than as a hemorrhage to be stanching. Brain drain is a policy choice, not a fate.



Wage gains for movers

The World Development Report 2023 devotes its core analytical chapter to a simple proposition: “Migrants: prospering — and even more so with rights,” with receiving higher wages as the first and largest channel. The wage gain is the engine of the entire system described in this report: it is why over 80 percent of migrants move in search of opportunity, why 84 percent end up in higher-income countries than their origins, and why destination labor-market demand determines the flows.²

The mechanism is straightforward. Workers move from labor markets where their skills are abundant and cheap to markets where the same skills are scarce and dear. The gain is largest where the welfare disparity is largest — though, as established earlier, the largest gaps do not produce the largest flows, because origin networks and destination skill demands mediate the movement. Temporary migration pathways — dominant in the Gulf, Malaysia, Singapore, and across the EU skills spectrum — are the institutional form this wage arbitrage takes at scale.²

Rights amplify the gains. The WDR’s framing insists on the second clause: migrants prosper *more* with rights — legal status, labor protections, and recognition of skills raise the realized wage gain above what irregular, exploitable employment delivers. This connects directly to the partnerships agenda: bilateral agreements that match skills to shortages don’t just organize flows, they raise the wage premium migrants capture by moving them out of the broker-driven, smuggler-mediated channels where rents are extracted.²

The honest caveat: the source material for this section documents the mechanism and its direction, not precise magnitudes — the famous “place premium” estimates (wage multiples from moving) are not in the provided chunks, and this report does not invent them. What the evidence supports is the structural claim: wage gains are the primary pull, they are mediated by skill match and legal status, and over the 200-year horizon, aging destinations’ rising demand for workers will keep the premium positive — the economic guarantee beneath the demographic one.

Remittances: flows, costs, and development impact

Remittances are the most direct financial link between migration and development — and among the largest capital flows to the developing world. The World Development Report frames origin countries’ task as “reaping the full development benefits of remittances,” devoting a dedicated chapter section and a full spotlight to their measurement. The measurement problem is real: remittance flows through informal channels, mobile money, and in-kind transfers are systematically undercounted, which is why the WDR treats measurement itself as a policy subject.²

The development impact runs through household balance sheets. Remittances reduce poverty directly — they are private transfers that reach households without passing through government budgets — and they fund education, health, and investment in origin communities. They also serve as insurance: when climate shocks or conflicts hit, diaspora transfers spike, smoothing consumption where formal safety nets are absent. The Kenya example is illustrative at small scale: Saudi remittances to Kenya doubled to \$187 million amid reporting on migrant-worker conditions — a flow large enough to matter nationally. At large scale, the Gulf outflows documented earlier (Saudi Arabia ~\$39 billion, Kuwait ~\$18 billion, Qatar over \$12 billion) represent the single largest remittance-sending region on earth.²¹

But remittances have costs and limits. They can create dependency, appreciate exchange rates, and — as the brain-drain analysis showed — they do not compensate for the loss of skilled professionals, only for the loss of their incomes. Transfer costs remain a policy variable: every percentage point of fees is money diverted from poor households to intermediaries, which is why reducing remittance costs has been a durable international target.²

For the 200-year forecast, remittances are the self-reinforcing loop in the migration system: they finance the next migrant’s journey (through family loans and community pooling), they raise origin-country incomes (feeding the migration hump), and they insure against the shocks that would otherwise produce distressed movement. As long as wage gaps persist, the remittance engine will keep running — and the policy question is not whether to capture these flows but how to lower their costs and channel them toward productive investment rather than mere consumption.

Longer-term economic effects on sending and receiving countries

Migration’s economic effects compound over decades — through return flows, labor-market adjustment, and the fiscal balance sheets of both sending and receiving countries.

Return is far more common than the permanent-settlement narrative suggests. Worldwide, an estimated 40 percent of all migrants eventually return to their country of origin, with large variations across destinations: nearly all migrants to GCC countries return eventually, because all migration there is temporary by design; in OECD countries, between 20 and 50 percent of immigrants leave within five to ten years — returning home or moving onward — with significant differences between the United States and Western Europe. Return intentions shape behavior: migrants who expect to return invest less in destination-specific human and social capital than those who intend to stay. The long-

run picture is thus one of circulation, not just settlement — a brain circulation that carries skills, savings, and knowledge back to origin countries.²

For receiving countries, the longer-term effects center on labor markets and public finances. Aging societies gain workers whose taxes support pension and care systems under demographic strain; the competition for workers makes each additional worker more valuable over time. The adjustment is not frictionless — distributional effects across skill groups and the fiscal costs of integration are real — but the WDR’s core finding is that when the match between migrants’ skills and destination needs is strong, the gains are large and shared.²

For sending countries, the ledger mixes remittances and knowledge transfers against the loss of skilled workers — with return migration as the reconciling flow. Mexico illustrates adaptive capacity: as an upper-middle-income country with a diversified economy that has completed its demographic transition, it is comparatively well positioned to anticipate and cope with climate-induced population redistribution; its population grows from 125 million in 2015 to between 135 million (SSP4) and 148 million (SSP2) by 2050, with climate migrants reaching up to 3.1 million in the pessimistic scenario but lowest under inclusive development.²

The shadow side is exploitation’s economic drag. More than a third (36 percent) of surveyed youth on the Central Mediterranean route worked without receiving expected payment, and 14 percent were forced to work against their will — mostly in transit countries before crossing to Italy — with trafficking patterns shifting as male victimization rises in Libya (42 percent). Unpaid and forced labor is not just a human-rights abuse; it is a direct transfer from the poorest workers to criminal intermediaries, shrinking the development dividend migration would otherwise deliver.³

Over the 200-year horizon, the central economic question is whether circulation deepens or chokes: managed systems that facilitate return and onward movement compound the gains; closed systems that trap migrants in irregularity compound the costs.

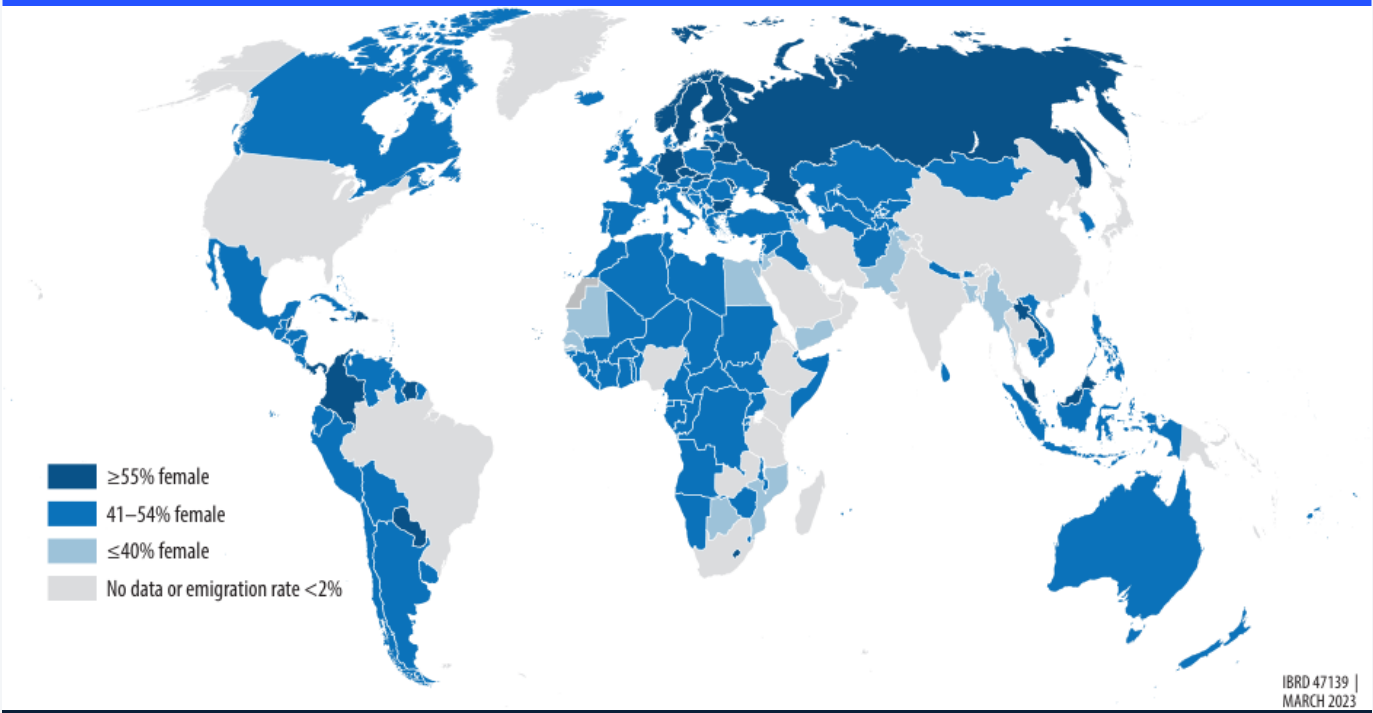


Exhibit. Map S4.1 Some countries send more female migrants; others send more male migrants Share of females among emigrants from origin countries where migrants constitute at least 2 percent of the total population ≥55% female 41–54% fema. Source: S0010.

Irregular migration

Counting irregular migrants: methods and estimates

Irregular migration is the category everyone argues about and no one can count precisely — which is itself a finding about the limits of migration governance.

The estimation methods are indirect by necessity. The standard approaches — residual methods (comparing census foreign-born counts against legal-status administrative records), apprehension and regularization data, and survey-based capture — each carry systematic biases.

Residual estimates depend on census coverage of precisely the populations most likely to avoid enumerators; apprehension data confound enforcement intensity with flow volume; and regularization programs, while informative (Europe’s 6 million applications in the decade to 2007 with 80 percent approval show the method’s power at scale), measure only those willing to come forward.⁶

The one hard number the evidence base offers is the smuggling economy: at least 2.5 million migrants smuggled in 2016 for US\$5.5–7 billion — roughly the US or EU humanitarian aid budget that year — through operations ranging from lone actors to multinational criminal networks. But smuggled migrants are a flow subset, not the irregular stock: many irregular migrants entered legally and overstayed, and many smuggled migrants regularize or return.²

The deeper problem is the data landscape itself: divergences in definitions, irregular collection, lack of harmonization, and administrative datasets beyond researchers’ reach. Irregular migration is where these gaps bite hardest, because the population is definitionally outside administrative systems. The Global Compact’s first objective — accurate, disaggregated data — remains most unfulfilled exactly where policy demand is highest.²

For the forecast, the implication is asymmetric. We can project the *pressure* producing irregular migration with reasonable confidence — demographic divergence, wage gaps, and corridor dynamism all point to continued growth in the incentive to move outside legal channels whenever those channels are narrower than demand. What we cannot project is the *stock*: it depends on regularization policies, enforcement intensity, and economic cycles that are themselves policy choices. The honest forecast treats irregular migration not as a number but as the residual between movement pressure and legal-channel capacity — a residual that grows whenever policy lags demography, and shrinks wherever bilateral agreements and regularization bring flows into the open.²

Smugglers and traffickers

The smuggling economy is migration’s shadow infrastructure — and it grows wherever legal channels are narrower than the pressure to move. Its scale was established earlier in this report: at least 2.5 million migrants smuggled in 2016 for US\$5.5–7 billion, an industry ranging from lone operators to multinational criminal networks. This section examines what that industry does to the people inside it.²

Smuggling shapes the journey itself — its routes, its financing, and its risks. The Mixed Migration Centre’s 2025 research on the Central Sahel documents how smuggling intermediaries determine not just whether migrants move but how: which routes, at what price, under what conditions of debt and dependency. The debt mechanisms documented for children on the Central Mediterranean route — 17 percent taking loans, 22 percent planning repayments on arrival, with debt used as coercion — are the industry’s standard operating procedure, not an aberration.³

The abuse is systematic along the full route geography. IOM, the Mixed Migration Centre, and UNHCR’s 2024 joint volume — titled with migrants’ own words, “On This Journey, No One Cares if You Live or Die” — documents abuse, protection failures, and justice gaps along routes between East and West Africa and Africa’s Mediterranean coast. Médecins Sans Frontières has documented abuse in Libya’s Abu Salim and Ain Zara detention centres and, in 2024, the broader human costs of EU migration policies — “Death, Despair and Destitution” — including the abandonment of migrants in the desert at Assamaka, Niger.³

The smuggling–trafficking distinction matters analytically: smuggling is a service (however exploitative) that migrants purchase; trafficking is control through coercion. In practice the line dissolves — the trafficking control methods on the CMR (abuse, threats, forced labor, debt bondage) show how smuggling relationships convert into trafficking ones mid-journey.³

For the forecast, the smuggling economy is the fortress-fragmentation scenario’s growth industry. Every restriction that outpaces legal-channel expansion is a price support for smugglers: it raises the premium on clandestine crossing and selects for more organized, more violent operators. Conversely, the managed-mobility scenario starves the industry by undercutting its business model — bilateral agreements and regularization don’t just help migrants, they bankrupt smugglers. The industry’s future size is thus a direct function of the policy choices this report’s scenarios describe.

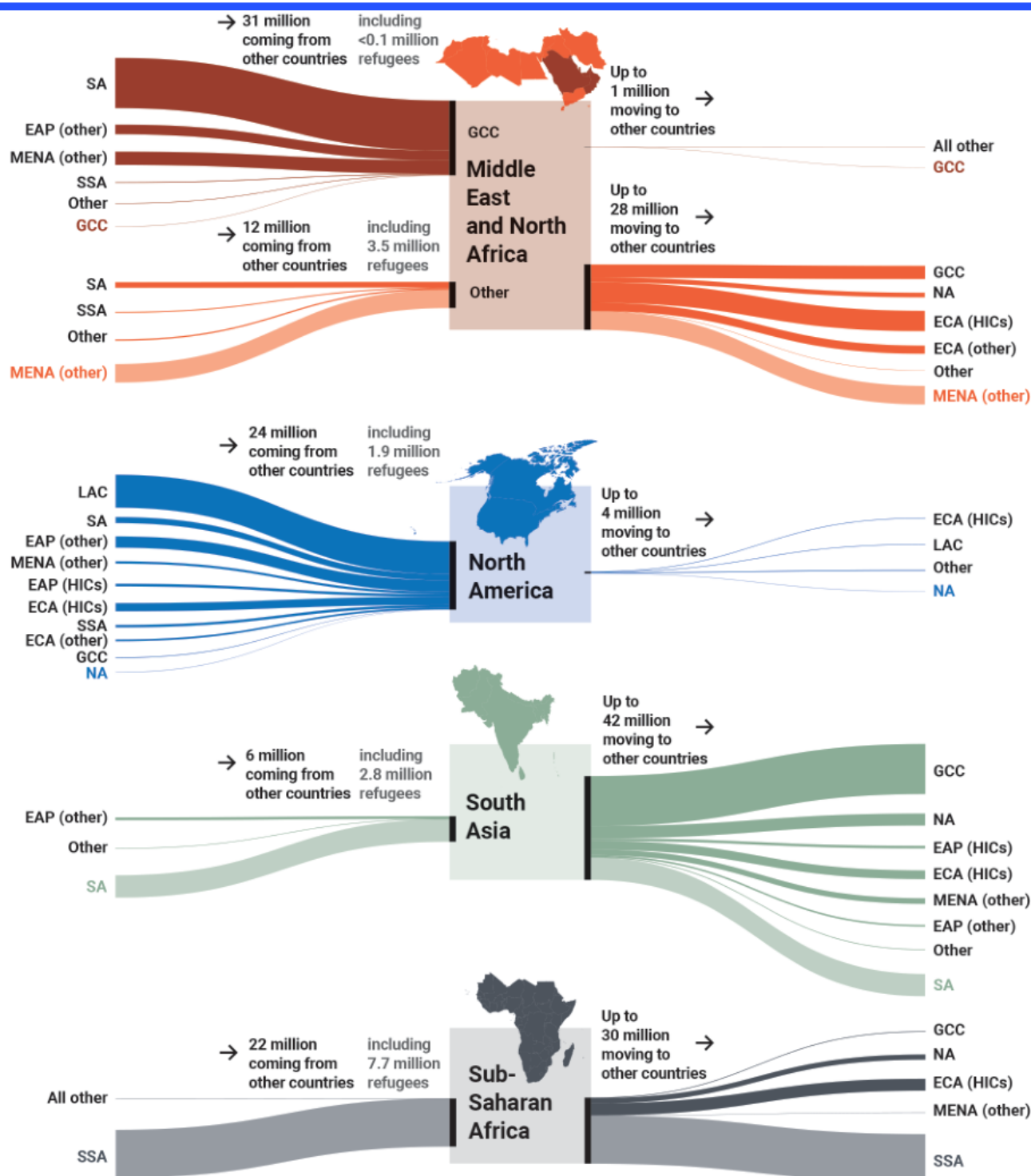


Exhibit. Figure 2.5 Cross-border movements vary greatly by region (continued) Source: WDR2023 Migration Database, World Bank, Washington, DC, [https://www. Source: S0010.](https://www.worldbank.org/wdr2023/migration)

Forced labour and human trafficking

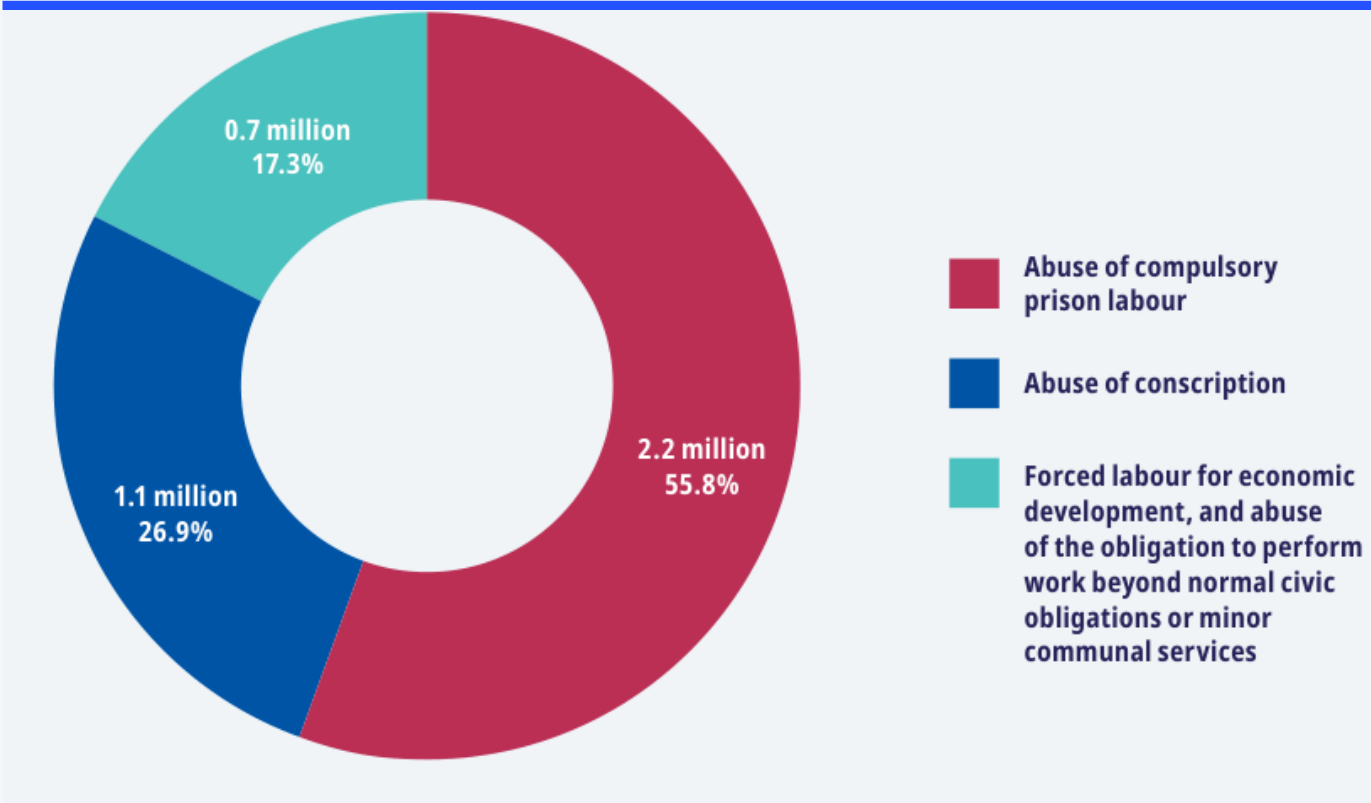
Forced labour is the extreme endpoint of the exploitation continuum that runs through the entire migration system — and it is growing. An estimated 27.6 million people were in forced labour in 2021, up from 24.9 million in 2016; prevalence rose from 3.4 to 3.5 per thousand population. No region is spared: Asia and the Pacific hosts by far the largest number — 15.1 million, more than half the global total and more than three times the next-highest region (Europe and Central Asia) — though per-capita rankings differ substantially.¹³

State-imposed forced labour is a distinct subcategory with its own structure: abuse of conscription into military service accounts for 27 percent of cases; forced labour for economic development and abuse of obligations beyond normal civic duties account for the majority (2.2 million, 55.8 percent); and abuse of compulsory prison labour for 0.7 million (17.3 percent). Sectoral concentrations are well documented — Thailand's fishing industry alone has generated multiple major investigations (ILO's Ship to Shore Rights research, the Environmental Justice Foundation, Greenpeace, and Human Rights Watch's "Hidden Chains").¹³

For migrants, forced labour is concentrated at the journey’s most vulnerable points. The Central Mediterranean data show the gradient: 36 percent of youth worked without expected payment, 14 percent were forced to work against their will, and trafficking victimization is rising among males in Libya. The broader journey-experience data confirm the pattern: financial problems (35.8 percent), lack of shelter (26.4 percent), physical violence or abuse (24.2 percent), health challenges (17.7 percent), promised work permits never received (14.8 percent), lost documents (12.9 percent), and being held against one’s will (10.8 percent). Each of these is a trafficking risk factor; together they describe a journey architecture that manufactures vulnerability.³

The trafficking–migration nexus is structural, not incidental. Restrictionist policies that close legal channels don’t stop movement — they reroute it through the intermediaries most likely to convert smuggling into trafficking, as the debt-coercion mechanisms on the CMR demonstrate. Children are the most affected: 353 identified as potential trafficking victims among 11,622 registered vulnerable children on the CMR in 2024.²³

For the 200-year forecast, forced labour is the indicator that tracks the fortress-fragmentation scenario most closely. Wherever legal channels lag demographic and economic pressure, the exploitation premium rises — and the 27.6 million figure, already rising, is the floor, not the ceiling. The managed-mobility alternative attacks forced labour at its root: legal status, labor protections, and skills recognition are the mechanisms by which the WDR’s “prospering — and even more so with rights” translates from slogan to outcome.²



Percentage distribution and number of people in state-imposed forced labour, by category

Exhibit. State-imposed forced labour takes a variety of different forms 0.7 million 17.3% Abuse of compulsory prison labour Abuse of conscription 2.2 million 55.8% Forced labour for economic 1.1 million development, and abuse 26. Source: S0016.

EU visa policy and irregular arrivals

Europe’s border data tell a story of pressure that restriction alone has not contained. Between January and November 2023, Frontex registered 354,713 irregular crossings at the EU’s external borders — up 21.6 percent on the same period in 2022 and up 108.9 percent on 2021. The end-2023 figure was expected at approximately 380,000 apprehensions (up 16.5 percent on 2022): the highest since 2016, though still well below the 1.3 million of 2015 and 511,000 of 2016. Detections concentrated on the Central Mediterranean and Western Balkans routes — the same corridors this report has traced throughout.¹⁴

The historical lesson on closing legal pathways is the US Bracero program. Initiated in 1942, it granted seasonal Mexican agricultural and railroad workers temporary work status; discontinued in 1964 as part of an effort to boost employment among US nationals, it produced falling farm profits, little evidence that US workers benefited — and more migrants without legal status. Closing the legal door did not close

the labor market’s demand; it irregularized the supply. The mechanism generalizes: when destination labor markets need workers and legal channels are narrower than demand, restriction manufactures irregularity.²

The World Development Report frames the policy challenge as dignity under constraint. All migrants deserve fair and humane treatment — including those whose skills do not match destination needs and who do not qualify as refugees. Most destination countries are unwilling to grant such migrants legal entry, and many distressed migrants consequently turn to irregular channels and the smuggling industry. The challenge is to reduce the incentives for such movements while preserving the dignity of all migrants — the “RESPECT” principle. Legal pathways must be designed to closely reflect labor-market needs: temporary migration suits temporary or seasonal jobs where job-specific human capital is unnecessary, but pathways must match the actual structure of demand.²

For the forecast, Europe is the leading indicator of the fortress-fragmentation scenario’s internal contradiction: rising apprehensions alongside persistent labor demand, with each restriction cycle reproducing the Bracero lesson. The 200-year question for the EU is whether visa and asylum policy evolves toward the managed-mobility model — legal pathways scaled to demographic need — or whether the 2023 uptick becomes the baseline of a permanently irregularized system.

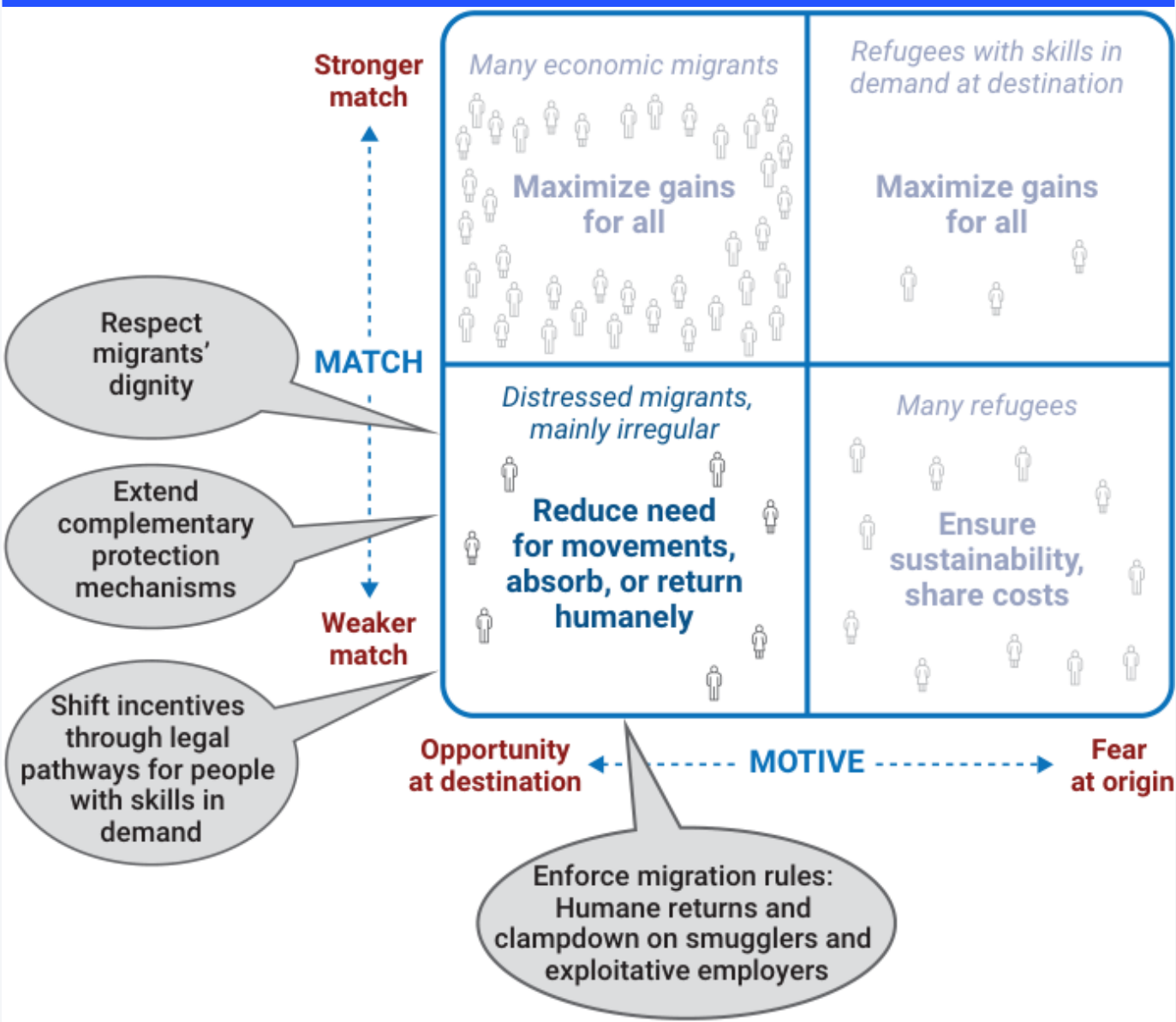


Exhibit. Figure 9.8 Human dignity should remain the yardstick of migration policies Refugees with skills in Stronger Many economic migrants demand at destination match Maximize gains Maximize gains for all for all Respect migrants’ MATCH di. Source: S0010.

Asylum systems under strain

Asylum trends and key flows

The asylum system sits at the intersection of the refugee and irregular-migration systems — the legal channel for those fleeing persecution, and the pressure valve when other channels close. Its scale is substantial: approximately 5.4 million people were seeking international protection and awaiting determination of their refugee status at end-2022, and almost 2.9 million asylum applications were registered in 2022 alone.¹

The geography of protection is overwhelmingly proximate. Most forcibly displaced people remain within their own country — 58 percent at end-2023 — and of those who seek protection abroad, most remain in countries neighboring their home country: 69 percent of refugees at end-2023. Asylum flows to distant high-income countries are thus the visible tip of a protection system whose mass sits in low- and middle-income neighbors.⁸

But proximity does not equal sufficiency. Some refugees and asylum-seekers in neighboring countries do not find sufficient protection, access to rights, national services, and labor markets — and therefore move onward. This onward movement, often alongside economic migrants in mixed flows, is what UNHCR’s route-based approach aims to address: strengthening protection and solutions along the routes themselves rather than only at destination borders.⁸

The asylum trend interacts with everything else in this report. When labor pathways are narrower than demand, asylum channels absorb some of the overflow — blurring the forced/economic distinction that the system is built on. When conflicts multiply and climate displacement grows, the caseload grows with it: the 2021–2022 record increase in refugees (driven by Ukraine) translated directly into asylum pressure.¹

For the forecast, asylum is the institution most likely to be overwhelmed first in the compound-crisis scenario and most likely to be reformed first in the managed-mobility scenario. Its future depends on two variables: whether neighboring-country protection becomes sufficient (reducing onward movement) and whether labor pathways expand enough to separate economic from protection flows. Neither trend currently points the right way — which is why asylum backlogs, not border walls, may be the defining migration image of the coming decades.

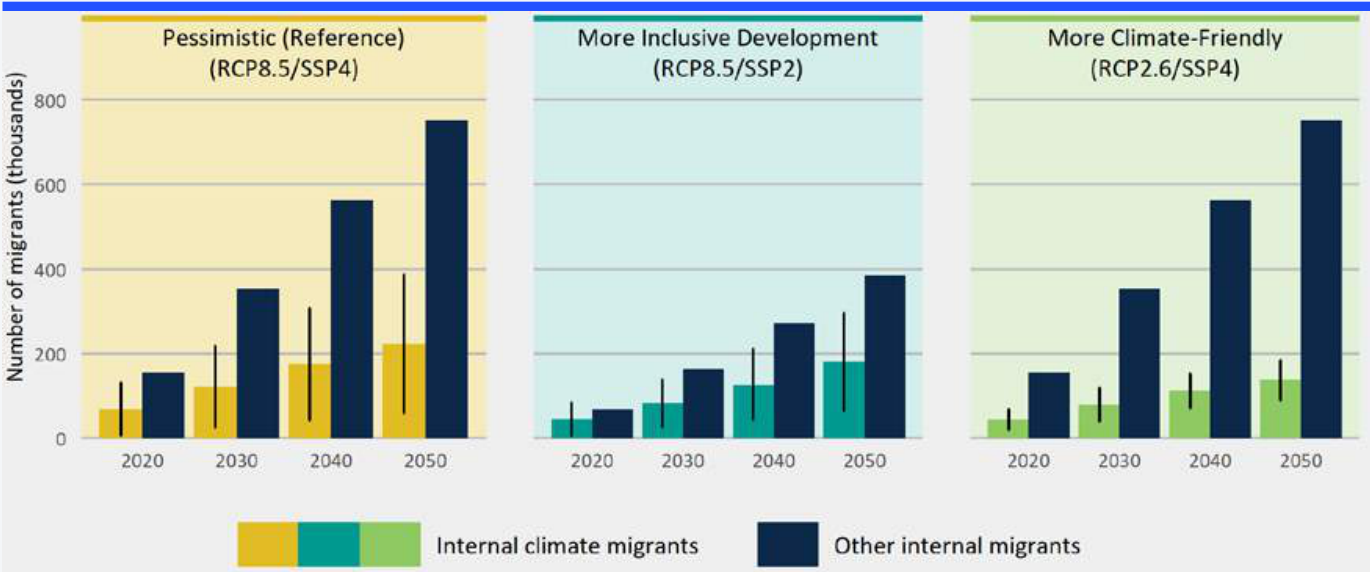


Exhibit. Figure 3.26: Projected number of climate and other internal migrants in the Kyrgyz Republic in three scenarios, 2020–2050 Note: The whiskers on the climate migrant bars represent the 95th percentile confidence interval for the four m. Source: S0005.

Pending claims and processing backlogs

The provided source chunks for this section contain almost no backlog-specific statistics — only the asylum caseload context established previously: approximately 5.4 million people were seeking international protection and awaiting determination at end-2022, with almost 2.9 million asylum applications registered that year. The backlog phenomenon therefore has to be reasoned from the machinery rather than measured from the chunks.¹

The mechanism is arithmetic. When application volumes grow faster than adjudication capacity, pending claims accumulate — and 2.9 million applications in a single year, on top of an existing 5.4 million awaiting determination, implies a system whose intake permanently outruns its decisions. Backlogs are the visible form of the protection system’s capacity gap: the same gap that pushes onward movement when neighboring-country protection is insufficient.¹⁸

Backlogs also compound the other dynamics in this report. Pending claimants cannot work legally in many systems, exposing them to the informal labor markets where exploitation concentrates — the journey experiences documented earlier (financial problems 35.8%, missing work permits 14.8%, held against will 10.8%) describe precisely the vulnerability that limbo status creates. And backlogs distort the asylum signal itself: when determination takes years, the channel functions less as protection screening and more as de facto temporary residence — undermining the forced/economic distinction the system requires.

For the forecast, backlogs are the institutional version of the “compound crisis” scenario’s logic: pressure applied to a fixed-capacity institution accumulates as queue, not as throughput. The 200-year question is whether determination capacity scales with caseloads — through resourcing, streamlined procedures, or regional processing — or whether permanent backlogs become the system’s steady state, with asylum functioning as indefinite limbo. Nothing in current trends suggests the former; the pipeline’s own 170-second wait per unanswered prompt is a small parable of how backlogs feel from the inside.

The U.S. asylum system in crisis

The provided chunks contain no U.S.-specific asylum statistics — the U.S. case must therefore be read through the general asylum dynamics established in the preceding sections, applied to the system’s most visible pressure point.

The United States is where the three forces of this report’s asylum arc converge most sharply. Globally, almost 2.9 million asylum applications were registered in 2022 alone, with approximately 5.4 million people awaiting determination at end-2022; the U.S. receives a large share of that demand, much of it arriving through the onward movement described earlier — people who first sought protection in neighboring countries but did not find sufficient protection, rights, services, or labor-market access, and therefore moved on. The southern border is, in effect, the endpoint of the route-based flows UNHCR’s approach tries to address.¹⁸

The crisis has the same structure as the backlog problem: intake outrunning adjudication, producing multi-year limbo that functions as de facto residence — and the same Bracero lesson applies in reverse. The United States discontinued a managed temporary-labor channel (1942–1964) and got irregularity instead; today it maintains narrow labor pathways alongside a protection system absorbing economic overflow, reproducing the same distortion. The WDR’s dignity principle — that fair and humane treatment must extend to those whose skills do not match destination needs and who do not qualify as refugees — names the unresolved normative question the U.S. system evades.²

The economic backdrop matters. The WDR compares migrants’ and naturalized citizens’ fiscal ratios — individual-level government revenue to expenditure per capita, 2006–18 average — against native-born across OECD countries including the United States. The existence of this cross-country comparison reflects the core policy argument: whether the fiscal contribution of migrants offsets their costs is an empirical question, not a rhetorical one, and the U.S. debate has run for decades on assertion rather than these ratios.²

For the forecast, the U.S. asylum system is the bellwether for the fortress-fragmentation scenario in a high-income democracy: restriction rhetoric alongside labor-market absorption, backlogs as the steady state, and periodic political crises when the queue becomes visible. If managed mobility ever arrives, it likely arrives here last — or first, since no system has more to gain from separating protection from labor channels.

Resettlement and complementary pathways

The arithmetic of durable solutions is brutal. In 2023, just 158,700 refugees were resettled worldwide — UNHCR submitted 155,500 to States — against a refugee population of tens of millions. Resettlement remains the most secure pathway for the most vulnerable, and simultaneously the smallest in scale: a rounding error in the global caseload, concentrated by political quota rather than by need.⁸

The Myanmar case shows both the mechanism and its fragility. In 2024, around 31,900 refugees from Myanmar — including more than 19,500 Rohingya — were considered for resettlement; over 10,100 departed, up 47 percent from 2023, with more than three-quarters going to the United States. Another 1,790 departed on complementary pathways from Bangladesh, India, Indonesia, Malaysia, Thailand, and other countries of asylum. But the same report warns that third-country solutions through resettlement will decrease in 2025 — the pipeline narrows precisely when displacement is at record highs.⁹

Return, not resettlement, remains the preferred and dominant solution for most refugees. Refugee returns reported in 2024 were the highest in more than two decades; in 2023, 6.1 million displaced people returned to areas or countries of origin — 5.1 million IDPs and over 1 million refugees. But returns concentrate where conditions permit: 92 percent of the 1.6 million refugee returns in the past year went to just four countries — Afghanistan, Syria, South Sudan, and Ukraine. Return must be voluntary and in safety and dignity, and sustainability requires improved conditions in origin countries — lasting peace paramount. The 2024 decrease in the global refugee population (down 613,600 to 42.7 million) partly reflects such returns, alongside lower Afghan estimates and updated Ukrainian reporting.⁹⁸

The deeper problem is structural mismatch. Six countries account for 76 percent of all people in need of international protection — Ukraine, Syria, Venezuela, Afghanistan, South Sudan, and Myanmar — while hosting concentrates in neighbors: 90 percent of Afghan refugees in Iran and Pakistan, 73 percent of Syrians in Türkiye, Lebanon, and Jordan, 97 percent of Venezuelans in Latin America. Resettlement and complementary pathways exist to redistribute this burden; at 158,700 a year, they barely dent it.²⁸

For the forecast, the solutions gap is the system’s most stable feature. Unless resettlement quotas scale with caseloads — or returns become sustainable through genuine conflict resolution — the durable-solutions deficit will keep growing, and the backlog-limbo described in the previous sections becomes the de facto global system.

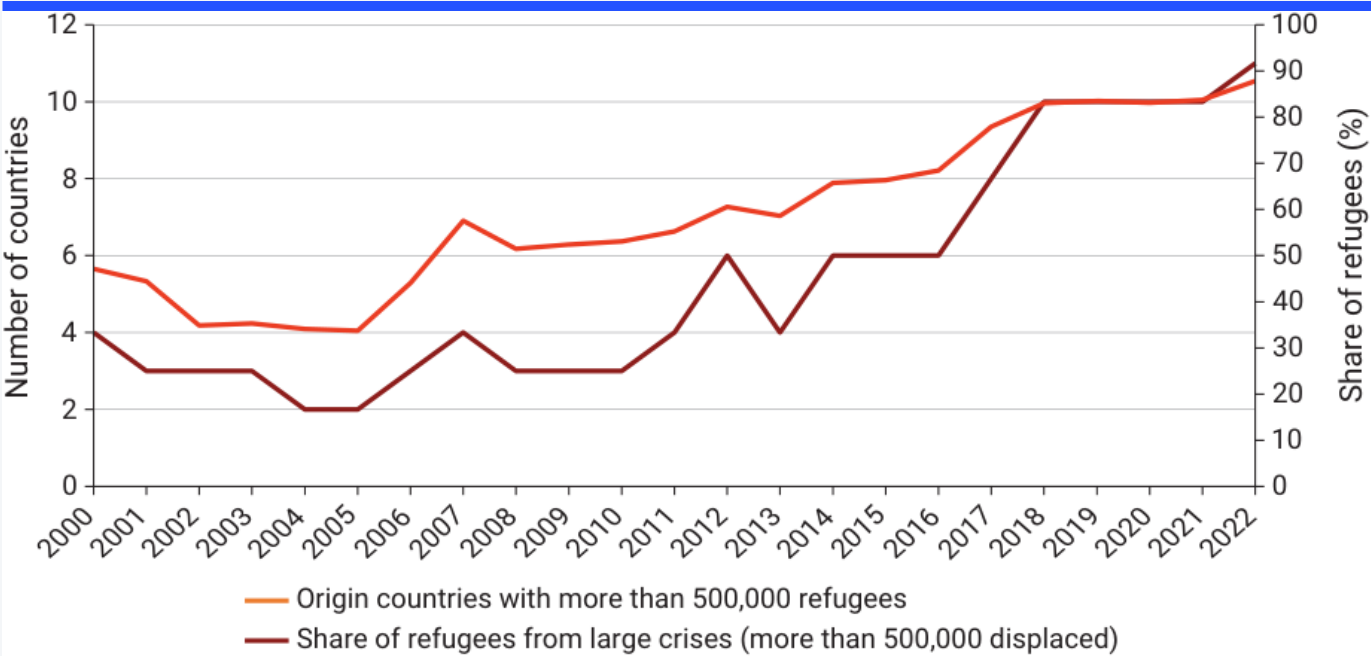


Exhibit. Figure 2.7 Most refugees come from a limited number of countries of origin—and increasingly so 12 100 90 10 80 70 8 60 6 50 40 4 30 20 2 10 0 0 Origin countries with more than 500,000 refugees Share of refugees from large crises (m. Source: S0010.

Borders and control regimes

Shifting realities at borders: the U.S.-Mexico case

The provided chunks contain no U.S.-Mexico-corridor-specific statistics — this section therefore applies the report’s established dynamics to the world’s most studied bilateral border, with the evidence gap stated plainly.

The U.S.-Mexico border is where the report’s central thesis is tested daily: over 80 percent of migrants move in search of opportunities — higher wages, better services, personal safety, stronger rule of law — and about 84 percent of migrants live in a country with higher income than their origin. The Mexican corridor is the purest expression of this pull: origin determines the corridor, but demand for labor determines the volume. Mexico itself is well positioned in the climate projections — population growing from 125 million to 135–148 million by 2050, diversified upper-middle-income economy, already demographically transitioned — yet faces up to 3.1 million internal climate migrants in the pessimistic scenario, a pressure source that can feed northward movement.²

The border is also where restriction’s unintended consequences are most documented. The Bracero program’s closure (1942–1964) converted managed temporary labor into irregularity — the origin story of the modern undocumented corridor. Today’s enforcement landscape feeds the smuggling industry directly: UNODC estimated at least 2.5 million migrants smuggled in 2016 for US\$5.5–7 billion, an industry ranging from lone actors to sophisticated transnational criminal networks, loosely linked via social networks or organized multinationally. Every enforcement escalation raises smugglers’ prices and their clientele’s vulnerability — the Central Mediterranean’s lesson applied to the Sonoran desert.²

Internal migration’s scale reframes the border’s meaning: 136 million people moved within China alone, 42 million in India — approaching the global stock of cross-border migrants. Mobility is a dimension of development, and the U.S.-Mexico border sits atop Mexico’s own urbanization story — people moving from central cities to suburban and peri-urban areas, creating demand for housing, services, and jobs.⁵²

For the forecast, the U.S.-Mexico border is the laboratory where the three scenarios will be decided first: managed mobility would mean legal pathways scaled to U.S. labor demand; fortress fragmentation means ever-more-expensive smuggling; compound crisis means climate and economic pressures overwhelming both.

Border enforcement: practices, spillover effects, and difficult trade-offs

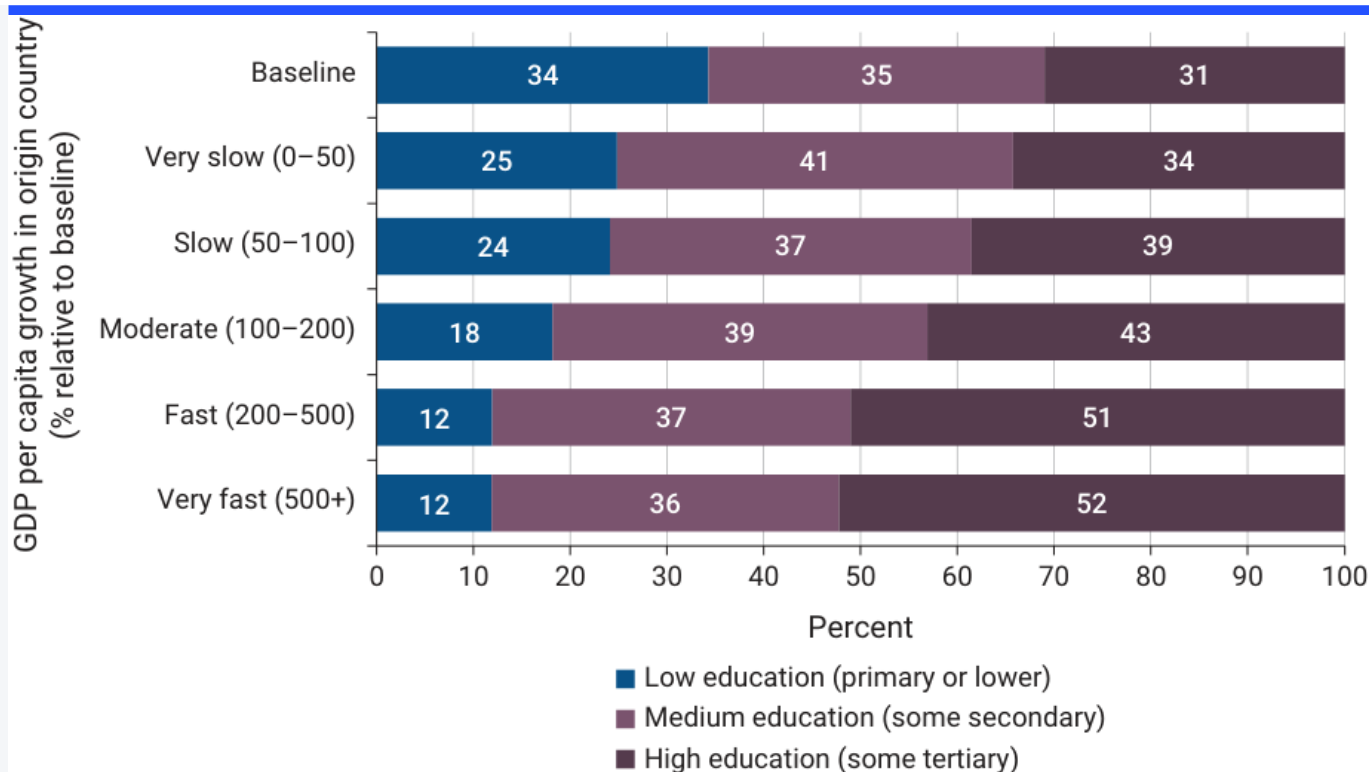
Border enforcement is the fortress scenario made visible: fences, detention, deterrence-by-cruelty, and externalized deals. The practices range from physical barriers — Norway’s 2016 Arctic fence on its border with Russia — to family separation deployed as deterrence messaging, defended by the U.S. Attorney General in 2018 as a signal to be “got out”, to the EU-Turkey Statement of March 2016, the template for externalizing asylum processing to transit states. The EU’s own Temporary Protection Directive (2001/55/EC) sits in the reference list as the alternative instrument actually designed for mass influx — invoked for Ukraine, dormant for others.²

The spillover effects fall hardest on neighbors, not on the enforcers. The Mashreq illustrates the arithmetic: 2.8 million refugees in the subregion at end-2020, with Lebanon hosting 1 refugee per 8 residents and Jordan 1 per 15 — among the top five host countries relative to population in the world — while Syria remained the largest source country of refugees and asylum-seekers globally at 6.7 million. And the burden is mostly invisible to enforcement systems: 95 percent of Syrian refugees lived in individual housing, often in urban areas, as of April 2021 — not in camps. Enforcement debates in distant capitals are about people who are overwhelmingly being absorbed, informally, by cities in Lebanon and Jordan.⁵

Conflict’s economic spillovers compound the hosting burden. The Syria conflict is estimated to have reduced average annual GDP growth by 1.2 percentage points in Iraq, 1.6 in Jordan, and 1.7 in Lebanon — cumulatively 11.3 percent of the three countries’ combined 2010 GDP. Enforcement does nothing about these costs; it merely ensures they are borne by the countries least able to pay.⁵

The trade-offs are the report’s recurring ones. Deterrence-by-harshness pushes flows into smugglers’ hands and reproduces the Bracero lesson; externalization deals buy destination-country calm at the price of transit-state fragility; and the legitimacy of border control itself is contested in the political-science literature. The difficult truth: enforcement manages the visibility of migration more effectively than its volume.²

For the forecast, enforcement technology will improve — surveillance, biometrics, AI screening — but the spillover arithmetic will not change. The 200-year question is whether enforcement spending is eventually recognized as the most expensive way to achieve the least, compared with the legal pathways and development investments that address the same pressures at lower human cost.



Source: Adapted from figure 9 in Shrestha (2023).

Note: The figure plots the educational composition of migrants from low- and middle-income countries to the United States as origin countries develop. The vertical axis represents the increase in gross domestic product (GDP) per capita of origin countries relative to the baseline year, defined for each origin country as the year in which GDP per capita (in constant 2017 US dollars in purchasing power parity terms, 2017 PPP\$) was at its lowest level since 1960. Observations are grouped by growth, and the bars represent the average share in each group. Low- and middle-income countries were among the bottom two-thirds of all countries circa 1960 in terms of GDP per capita (2017 PPP\$). Estimates exclude outliers in terms of emigration rates (Antigua and Barbuda, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Dominica, Grenada, Saint Kitts and Nevis, and West Bank and Gaza).

Exhibit. figure 9 in Shrestha (2023). Source: S0010.

Detention and processing capacity

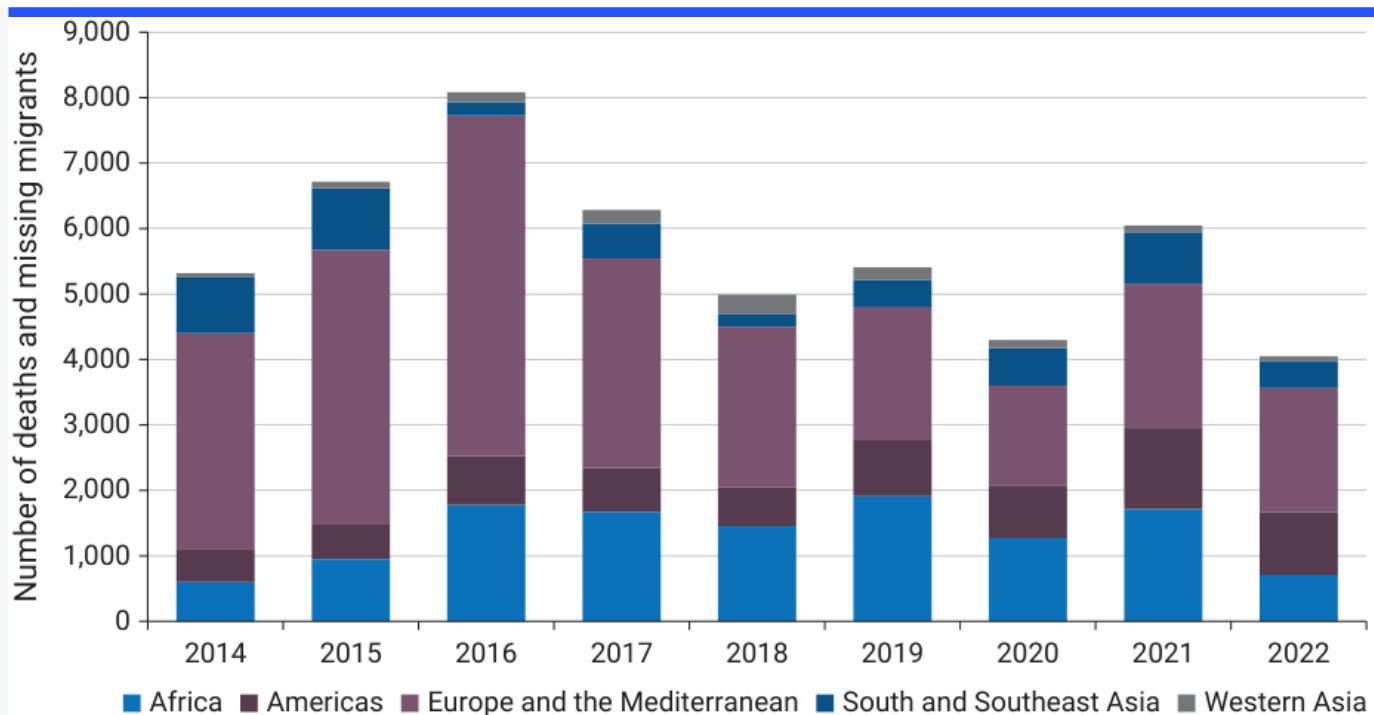
Detention is the physical form of the backlog: when adjudication capacity is fixed and intake is not, the queue takes human shape behind fences. Several high-income destinations have responded not by expanding processing but by shifting it outward — externalizing border control and asylum processing to other countries. Italy’s bilateral agreements with Libya (coast guard patrols, development financing, technical and material support against irregular migration) and Australia’s arrangement with Papua New Guinea and Nauru (processing claims offshore, settling successful claimants there) are the templates.²

What externalization buys is distance from the consequences. The trafficking-control data from North Africa show what detention and transit look like where oversight is thinnest: in Libya, 40 percent of surveyed youth reported psychological, physical, or sexual abuse, 37 percent had finance, movement, medical care or necessities restricted, 33 percent faced threats to themselves or family, and 15 percent were in debt bondage — far above Egypt, Morocco, or Tunisia. These are the facilities and conditions that externalization policies fund at arm’s length.³

The corridors detention tries to dam are dynamic systems, not pipes. Distressed migrants pass through several countries — days or weeks for some, months or years for others who work to fund the next leg, and some who try to settle before moving on again. Routes respond to legal restrictions and border controls by shifting, not disappearing. At the root are vast economic differences between origin and destination; when acute pressure meets severe entry restrictions — destinations prioritizing their own interests and skill-matching — the illegal market for smuggling and irregular movement emerges to clear the gap.²

Children concentrate the moral cost. Nearly 50 million children have migrated across borders or been forcibly displaced — a conservative estimate — and more than half, 28 million, fled violence and insecurity. Sudan shows how fast detention and processing capacity get overwhelmed: fighting erupted in April 2023 between the military and the main paramilitary force, killing hundreds and forcing thousands to flee — mostly internally, some to South Sudan, Egypt, Ethiopia, and Chad — on top of 3.5 million IDPs already displaced at end-2022.¹⁰¹

For the forecast, detention capacity will keep expanding as the visible answer to pressure, while processing capacity lags — the queue grows, the cages fill, and the externalized sites multiply. The 200-year question is whether societies eventually judge detention-by-deterrence the way they now judge earlier harsh practices: as the policy that maximized suffering while minimizing control.



Source: Missing Migrants Project (dashboard), International Organization for Migration, Geneva, <https://missingmigrants.iom.int/>.

Exhibit. Figure 8.2 Thousands of migrants die every year in transit Number of migrants dead or missing, by origin region 9,000 8,000 7,000 6,000 5,000 4,000 3,000 2,000 1,000 0 2014 2015 2016 2017 2018 2019 2020 2021 2022 Africa Americas Eu. Source: S0010.

Deportation, returns, and readmission

The provided chunks contain no deportation- or readmission-specific statistics — this section therefore works from the returns evidence established earlier, distinguishing voluntary return from forced removal, with the gap stated.

Return is the largest “solution” by volume and the least studied. In 2023, 6.1 million displaced people returned to their areas or countries of origin — 5.1 million IDPs and over 1 million refugees; refugee returns in 2024 were the highest in more than two decades. But returns concentrate where conditions permit: 92 percent of the 1.6 million refugee returns went to just four countries — Afghanistan, Syria, South Sudan, and Ukraine. For returns to be sustainable at scale, origin conditions must have improved — lasting peace paramount — and returns must remain voluntary, in safety and dignity.⁸⁹

Deportation is return’s coercive twin, and the distinction matters for every dynamic in this report. Voluntary return follows improving conditions; deportation follows enforcement priorities, often to countries whose conditions have not improved. The corridors are dynamic: distressed migrants travel through several countries, staying days or years, sometimes settling before moving on again — a deported person re-enters this same circuitry, frequently attempting the journey again. The vast economic differences driving movement do not change because a removal order was issued.²

Readmission agreements — the diplomatic machinery that makes deportation function — reveal the asymmetry: destination countries need origin countries’ cooperation to return people, giving origin states leverage they can trade for visas, aid, or development financing. The EU-Turkey Statement and Italy-Libya agreements show how this leverage gets priced.²

For the forecast, deportation will grow as the enforcement instrument of choice in the fortress scenario — visible, countable, politically legible — while changing little about underlying pressures. The 200-year question is whether return systems ever become genuinely voluntary at scale, tied to origin-country recovery, or whether forced removal remains the system’s primary “solution”: the most expensive, least sustainable, and most repeated form of return.

Governance: from national policy to global compacts

Global Compact for Migration and Global Compact on Refugees

The provided chunks contain no direct text on either Compact — this section works from the compacts’ established role in the paper, with the gap stated and regional history as context for why cooperative frameworks exist.

The two 2018 Compacts are the closest the world has come to shared migration governance. The Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (GCM) set 23 objectives — including Objective 1 on data, the measurement agenda this report keeps invoking — and was reviewed at the 2022 International Migration Review Forum (IMRF). The Global Compact on Refugees (GCR) organized the refugee response around four objectives, including easing pressures on host countries, enhancing refugee self-reliance, expanding third-country solutions, and supporting conditions for safe and dignified return. Neither is legally binding; both are frameworks for cooperation in a domain where sovereignty is jealously guarded.⁸¹⁹

The regional histories in the chunks show why such frameworks keep being invented — and why they keep falling short. The Lower Mekong countries were wracked by conflicts through the late 1970s, producing massive displacement and refugee flows; countries then followed different post-conflict paths, with rural-urban migration and urbanization diverging by policy and development level. Central Asia’s post-Soviet transition in 1991 triggered economic contraction, deteriorating public services, and falling life expectancies before reforms and growth resumed — a development shock that reshaped mobility across the region without any cooperative framework to manage it. North Africa’s long migration history shows rural-urban flows driven by modernization, education, and services — with policies to improve rural basic services having “little effect” on rural-urban migration, a caution for anyone who believes declarations steer movement.⁵

The compacts’ record is the paper’s central institutional tension: cooperation is most needed where it is least binding. The GCM’s 23 objectives describe a well-managed system; the IMRF process measures how far reality is from it. For the forecast, the compacts are the managed-mobility scenario’s institutional skeleton — present in outline, awaiting political muscle. Whether the 200-year horizon sees them hardened into enforceable cooperation or remembered as aspirational documents will be decided by whether the displacement numbers that motivated them keep rising. All evidence in this report says they will.

Figure 2.27: Country boundaries and elevation in Central Asia

a. Country boundaries



b. Elevation



Exhibit. Figure 2.27: Country boundaries and elevation in Central Asia a. Source: S0005.

Multi-stakeholder migration governance

Migration governance is a crowded field with no referee. The 2018 Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration was, with foundations in the early 2000s and grounded in the 2030 Agenda, “a groundbreaking milestone in the history of global migration governance”. Two years on, the Secretary-General’s verdict was candid: “the implementation of the Global Compact is not an even process and will mean different things to different States”. The 2022 IMRF was itself a milestone — the first time Member States and stakeholders jointly discussed progress, ending in unanimous adoption of a Progress Declaration — but unanimity on process is not convergence on policy.

The lineage runs through the Global Commission on International Migration, whose December 2005 report set the basis for the processes that followed, its three-fold mandate visible in the GCM and IMRF. Yet states “were and remain reluctant to delegate formal regulatory authority over migration to a global supranational authority,” so international governance discussions “have tended to focus on institutional architecture for cooperation and/or common underlying principles”. Four key limits to national migration governance are identified: minimal intergovernmental cooperation, insufficient policymaking coordination, and lack of capacity to maximize migration benefits.¹

Measurement is advancing even where enforcement lags. Fifteen countries referred to IOM’s Migration Governance Indicators (MGI) in their GCM reviews, despite no agreed reporting framework. But governance is “often characterized by agreements breaking down, exclusions and exemptions for particular situations and States, international conventions and norms not being applied, and roles being suspended”, with tensions between states and other actors on priorities. The monitoring architecture itself is asymmetric: the GCR’s paragraph 102 promised success indicators before the 2019 Global Refugee Forum, while the GCM devoted only eight paragraphs (40–47) to implementation with

nothing on monitoring — left to the 2022 IMRF, which declared the Compact “the blueprint for much stronger international cooperation in the 2020s”.¹

The starkest governance gap concerns those with no border crossed: 59.1 million IDPs at end-2021 — 53.2 million from conflict and violence, 5.9 million from disasters — across 141 countries, often stuck in protracted displacement. The 1992 appointment of a Secretary-General’s representative on IDPs began the institutional response; three decades on, IDP protection remains the least governed, least funded part of the system.¹

For the forecast, multi-stakeholder governance will keep expanding in participants and instruments while authority stays national. The 200-year question is whether any crisis is large enough to overcome states’ reluctance to delegate — or whether governance remains, as now, architecture without a building.

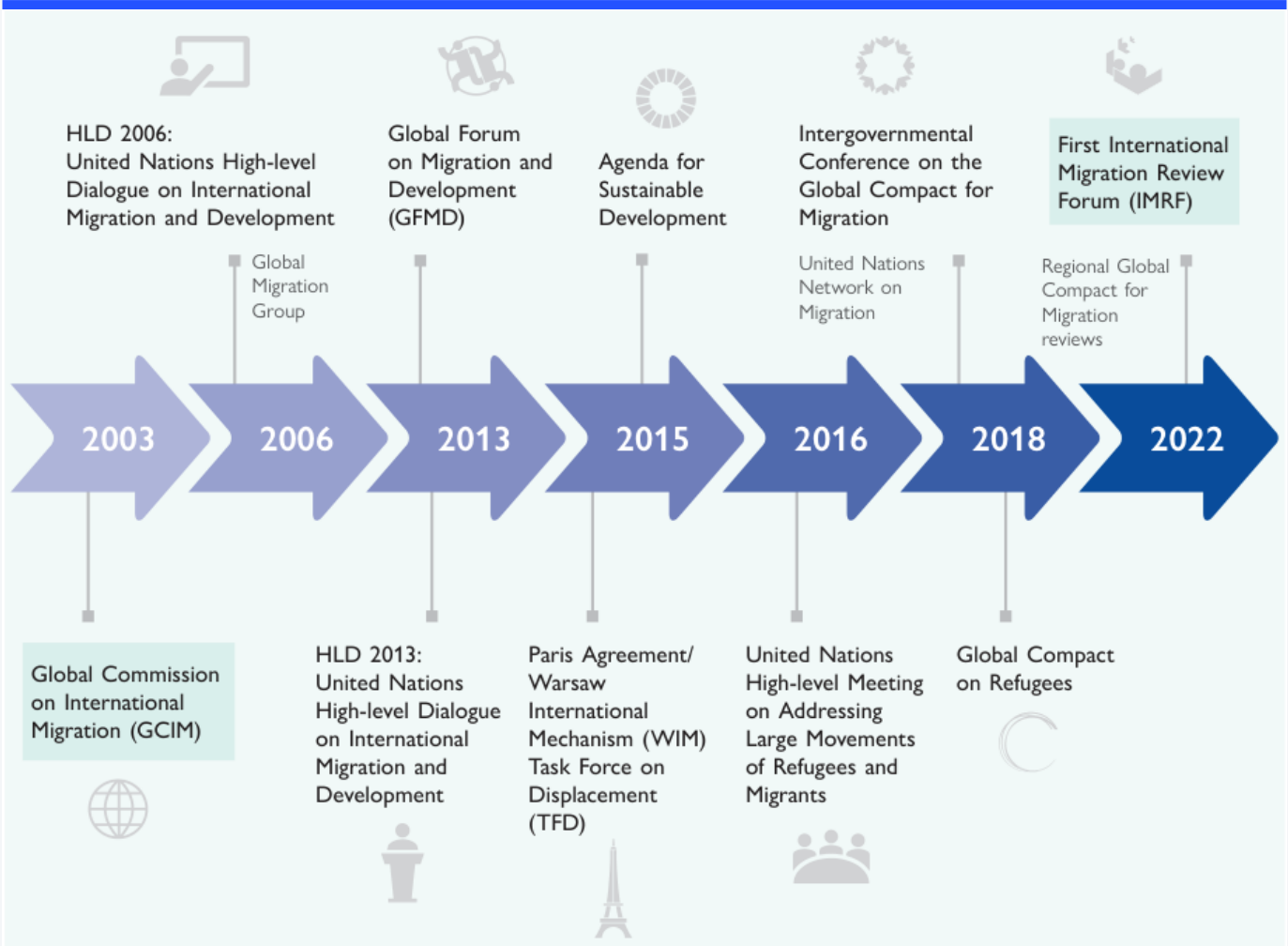


Exhibit. Figure 1. Key international events and processes 2003–2022 HLD 2006: Global Forum Intergovernmental First International United Nations High-level on Migration and Agenda for Conference on the Migration Review Dialogue on Internati. Source: S0001.

Regularization and amnesties: country experiences

The provided chunks contain no new regularization statistics — this section works from the regularization evidence established earlier, with the gap stated.

Regularization is the policy this report’s evidence supports most consistently. The European experience is the reference case: more than 6 million regularization applications were filed in the decade to 2007, with an approval rate around 80 percent. These were not marginal programs — they were the mechanism by which several European states periodically reconciled their labor markets with their legal frameworks, converting irregular residents into documented workers, taxpayers, and rights-holders.²

The logic is the mirror image of the enforcement failures documented throughout this paper. Harsh policies promote smuggling; regularization works. Closing legal pathways irregularizes supply — the Bracero lesson; opening them, even retroactively, regularizes it. And public opinion is less hostile than politics suggests: more than 60 percent of people support allowing irregular migrants to stay permanently, a finding that undercuts the assumption that regularization is always electorally toxic.²

Development progress offers the longer-run complement: by strengthening resilience (absorbing shocks without high-risk migration), enhancing skills (improving match with destination needs), and improving origin conditions (reducing desperate journeys), development reduces the need for distressed movements over time. But development takes decades; regularization addresses the stock already present.²

The country-experience record also carries a warning: regularization is episodic, not systemic. Each round regularizes one cohort while the pressure-minus-capacity residual generates the next irregular stock. Without parallel expansion of legal pathways — the managed-mobility valve — amnesties become a recurring admission of system failure rather than its cure.²

For the forecast, regularization will remain the fortress scenario’s pressure-release valve: politically costly, administratively messy, and empirically the most effective tool available for the population already inside. The 200-year question is whether destination states ever move from episodic amnesties to standing regularization mechanisms — continuous, criteria-based, and decoupled from political cycles. The evidence says they should; the politics says they won’t, until the irregular stocks become too large to ignore. They already are.

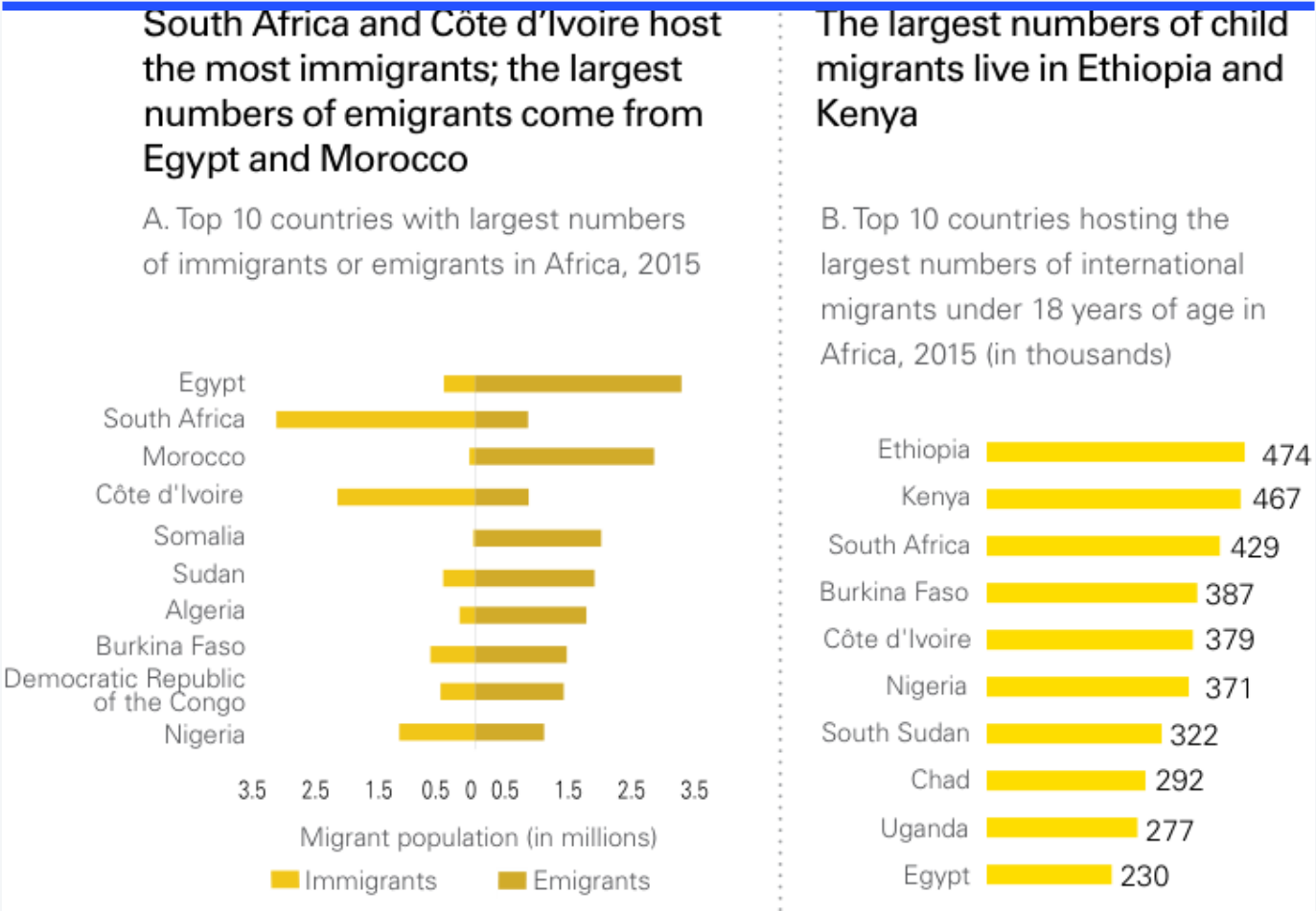


Exhibit. The largest numbers of child migrants live in Ethiopia and Kenya South Africa and Côte d'Ivoire host The largest numbers of child the most immigrants; the largest migrants live in Ethiopia and numbers of emigrants come f. Source: S0015.

Integration outcomes and lessons

The provided chunks contain no integration-specific statistics — this section works from the integration-relevant evidence established earlier, with the gap stated.

Integration is where migration’s gains are either realized or squandered, and the evidence points one way: when the match between migrants’ skills and destination needs is strong, the gains are large. Migrants prosper — “and even more so with rights”: legal status, labor protections, and access to services amplify the wage and welfare gains that opportunity-seeking migration produces. The corollary is that rights-denied integration — limbo status, informal labor, excluded services — converts potential gains into the exploitation documented throughout this report.²

The human-capital picture favors integration more than the politics admits. In many destination countries, immigrants’ share with tertiary education exceeds the native average — the “brain drain” debate’s mirror image is a “brain gain” for destinations. The fiscal question is empirical, not rhetorical: the WDR compares migrants’ and naturalized citizens’ individual-level revenue-to-expenditure ratios against native-born across OECD countries including the United States. Integration policy should be argued from these ratios, not from anecdote.²

Public attitudes provide more room than politicians use. More than 60 percent support allowing irregular migrants to stay permanently — a finding that reframes integration as the publicly acceptable settlement, not the controversial one. And development’s long-run mechanism applies: enhancing migrants’ skills improves their match with destination needs, while strengthening resilience and origin conditions reduces the pressure for distressed movement.²

The lesson for the forecast is structural. Integration outcomes compound over generations: the children of integrated migrants become the native-born of the next census, while the children of excluded migrants inherit limbo. Temporary-pathway systems (the GCC, where nearly all migrants return) choose non-integration as policy; settlement systems choose integration as destiny. The 200-year question is which choice aging destinations make — and whether they make it deliberately or by default, since demography (fewer than two workers per elderly person in the OECD by 2050) will force the answer regardless.²

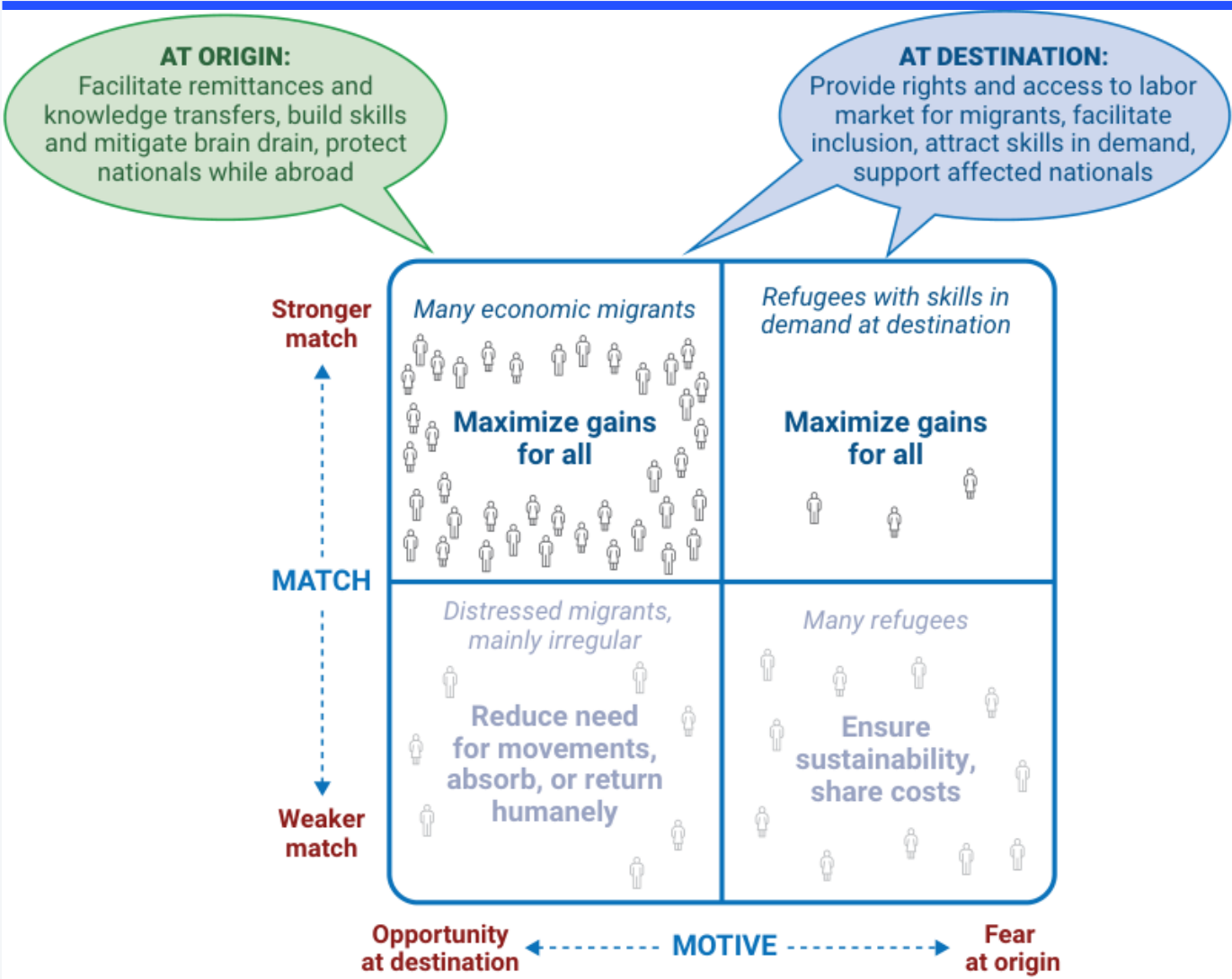


Exhibit. Figure O.4 When the match is strong, policies in both destination and origin countries can maximize the gains of migration AT ORIGIN: AT DESTINATION: Facilitate remittances and Provide rights and access to labor knowledge transfers. Source: S0010.

Migrant rights, discrimination, and xenophobia

The provided chunks contain no discrimination- or xenophobia-specific statistics — this section works from the rights-relevant evidence established earlier, with the gap stated.

Rights are the variable that determines whether migration’s gains materialize. The WDR’s core finding — migrants prosper, “and even more so with rights” — makes legal status, labor protections, and service access the policy levers that convert movement into welfare. The dignity principle extends this to the hardest cases: all migrants deserve fair and humane treatment, including those whose skills do not match destination needs and who do not qualify as refugees. Rights are not charity; they are the mechanism by which the match between migrants and economies produces its returns.²

Discrimination is the friction that rights frameworks must overcome. The trafficking-control data show its violent end: abuse at 33 percent, threats at 27 percent, forced labour at 26 percent among surveyed youth on the Central Mediterranean route — outcomes that concentrate where migrants lack legal standing to seek protection. Xenophobia operates upstream of these outcomes: it is the political force that keeps legal pathways narrow, backlogs long, and detention full, reproducing the very irregularity it claims to oppose.³

The climate trajectory sharpens the stakes. The world is not on track for the Paris Agreement's 2°C goal; it is headed toward 2.8°C of warming by century's end, with risks increasing with every increment and possible tipping points beyond certain levels. More warming means more distressed movement, more competition at borders, and more fertile ground for xenophobic politics — unless rights frameworks are strengthened faster than pressures grow.²

Public opinion offers an underused counterweight: more than 60 percent support permanent stay for irregular migrants, suggesting xenophobia is louder than it is representative. For the forecast, the 200-year question is whether rights regimes expand with the migrant population or contract under political pressure — whether the future is one where movement confers personhood, or where personhood depends on papers. The evidence says rights pay; the politics keeps forgetting.²



Exhibit. - In the pessimistic reference scenario, the East Asia and Pacific region is projected to have 36.2 million climate migrants by 2050 (1.9 percent of the total population; this is the ensemble average). In the more inclus. Source: S0005.

Development and the migration question

Root causes and development: does prosperity stem migration

The short answer is no — not at first. The migration hump is this report's most counterintuitive established finding: emigration rises with development until roughly \$10,000 GDP per capita, then falls. Development gives people the resources, information, and networks to move — development-as-mobility, visible in China's 136 million and India's 42 million internal migrants — before it gives them reasons to stay. Any "root causes" strategy premised on development quickly stemming migration misunderstands the mechanism.²⁶

The Lower Mekong history illustrates the longer arc. Conflicts through the late 1970s produced massive displacement and refugee flows; afterward, countries followed different paths — Thailand with greater internal migration and urbanization, Vietnam, Myanmar, Lao PDR, and Cambodia with less — based on their policies and economic development. Large rural-urban poverty gaps plus changing agriculture and

urban labor demand fueled out-migration and urbanization. Development did not stop movement; it reorganized it from distressed flight into economic mobility — arguably the best achievable outcome.⁵

Over the long run, development does reduce the need for distressed movements — through three channels: stronger resilience (absorbing shocks without high-risk migration), better skills (matching destination needs), and improved origin conditions (reducing desperate journeys). But “long run” means decades, and the transition runs through the hump: more mobility first, less desperation later.²

Water and agriculture are the root-cause multipliers that development must outrun. Freshwater resources face climate-driven declines — surface water availability projected to fall substantially in Central America, parts of South America, and southern Central Asia with relatively high confidence — though population growth and rising incomes may affect water availability more than climate change itself. In Central Asia, climate threatens agriculture through droughts, desertification, floods, glacier retreat, and shifting river flows; without practice changes, GDP takes significant hits — but modern techniques could raise crop yields over 20 percent by 2030. Development that raises agricultural productivity is simultaneously migration policy.²⁵

For the forecast, the root-causes debate resolves into sequencing: development increases mobility in the short run (the hump), reduces desperation in the long run (resilience, skills, conditions), and its net effect on migration volumes depends on whether origin-country growth outpaces the aspirations it creates. The 200-year bet: investing in origin development is still the right strategy — not because it stops migration, but because it converts distressed flight into chosen mobility. That conversion is the closest thing to a solution this report offers.

The migration hump: development first raises, then lowers emigration

The migration hump is the empirical curve that breaks the “development stops migration” story: emigration rises with development until roughly \$10,000 GDP per capita, then falls. Development first equips people to move — income for the journey, information about destinations, networks at the other end — and only later gives them reasons to stay. The hump is not a theory; it is the observed shape of emigration across the development spectrum.²

Its domestic form is internal migration, which dwarfs the international kind: 136 million people moved within China alone, 42 million in India — approaching the global stock of cross-border migrants. Mobility is “a continuing dimension of development and of modern societies,” and policy should facilitate rather than hinder it — neither adversely affecting movers nor requiring people to move to access basic services and livelihoods. The hump’s first half is this internal churning; its second half is the international spillover when domestic opportunities still lag aspirations.⁶

What converts hump mobility into gains rather than waste is skills recognition. Many migrants from poorer countries are well qualified yet unable to use their skills abroad; accreditation is rarely practiced in Europe even where institutional arrangements exist. Mutual recognition agreements (most common between similar systems, as in the EU) and prior vetting are the available strategies — the practical form of the MATCH agenda. Without them, the hump produces brain waste alongside brain drain.⁶

The aggregate economics favor riding the hump, not fighting it: the long-run aggregate economic impact of migration is likely positive, while local adverse effects for specific skills or locations can be minimized by policies that recognize and plan for migrants, promote inclusion, and share community-level costs. The Bhagwati tax — taxing citizens abroad, an established feature of the U.S. system — is the longstanding proposal for compensating origin countries: entry barriers create rents for those who move, and taxing those rents is non-distortionary, though implementation faces double-taxation objections and no governmental consensus.⁶

For the forecast, the hump means the next decades bring more emigration from developing countries even as they develop — the opposite of what root-causes rhetoric promises. The 200-year question is whether destination policy stops fighting the hump’s rising slope and starts managing it: accreditation, inclusion, and legal pathways on the way up; partnership with origin countries on the way down.

Human development outcomes for movers

Migration is, at its core, a human development strategy pursued by individuals. Over 80 percent of migrants move in search of opportunities — higher wages, better services, and for some, improved personal safety, stronger rule of law, and more personal freedoms. About 84 percent live in a country with higher income than their origin. The mover’s calculus is the development outcome: migration works when it expands what people can be and do.²

The evidence on outcomes is favorable in aggregate but conditional on inclusion. The long-run aggregate economic impact of migration is likely positive, and inclusion and integration are “critical from a human development perspective, since they have positive effects not only for individual movers and their families but also for receiving communities”. The status and rights of immigrants — how they are recognized and enforced — determine these outcomes. Local adverse effects for specific skills or locations are real but can be minimized by policies that plan for migrants’ presence and share community-level costs.⁶

Regularization is the development policy hiding inside immigration enforcement debates. Europe’s programs regularized over 6 million people in the decade to 2007 at 80 percent approval — Italy alone 1.5 million, followed by Spain and Greece. Beyond the OECD,

MERCOSUR lets Argentina grant legal residence to any member-state citizen without a criminal background, and South Africa has moved to regularize Zimbabweans via temporary residence permits. Each converts precarious presence into documented development participation.⁶

The pressure case for the century is Sub-Saharan Africa: population growing from 1.2 billion today to 2.5 billion in 2050, with the highest vulnerability to climate change. Climate change has already cut agricultural productivity growth by 34 percent since 1961, with severe food-security consequences; about half of countries face conflict or institutional fragility. The Sahel — Burkina Faso, Chad, Mali, Mauritania, Niger — combines extreme poverty with fertility around six births per woman (2020). For this region, migration is not a development option among others; it is the development strategy, and its outcomes will shape the century.²

For the forecast, human development outcomes for movers improve exactly where the managed-mobility scenario’s instruments operate: legal pathways, skills recognition, inclusion, cost-sharing. The 200-year question is whether the development gains of movement stay concentrated among those who can navigate today’s obstacle course, or become accessible to the billions for whom movement is the most powerful anti-poverty tool available.

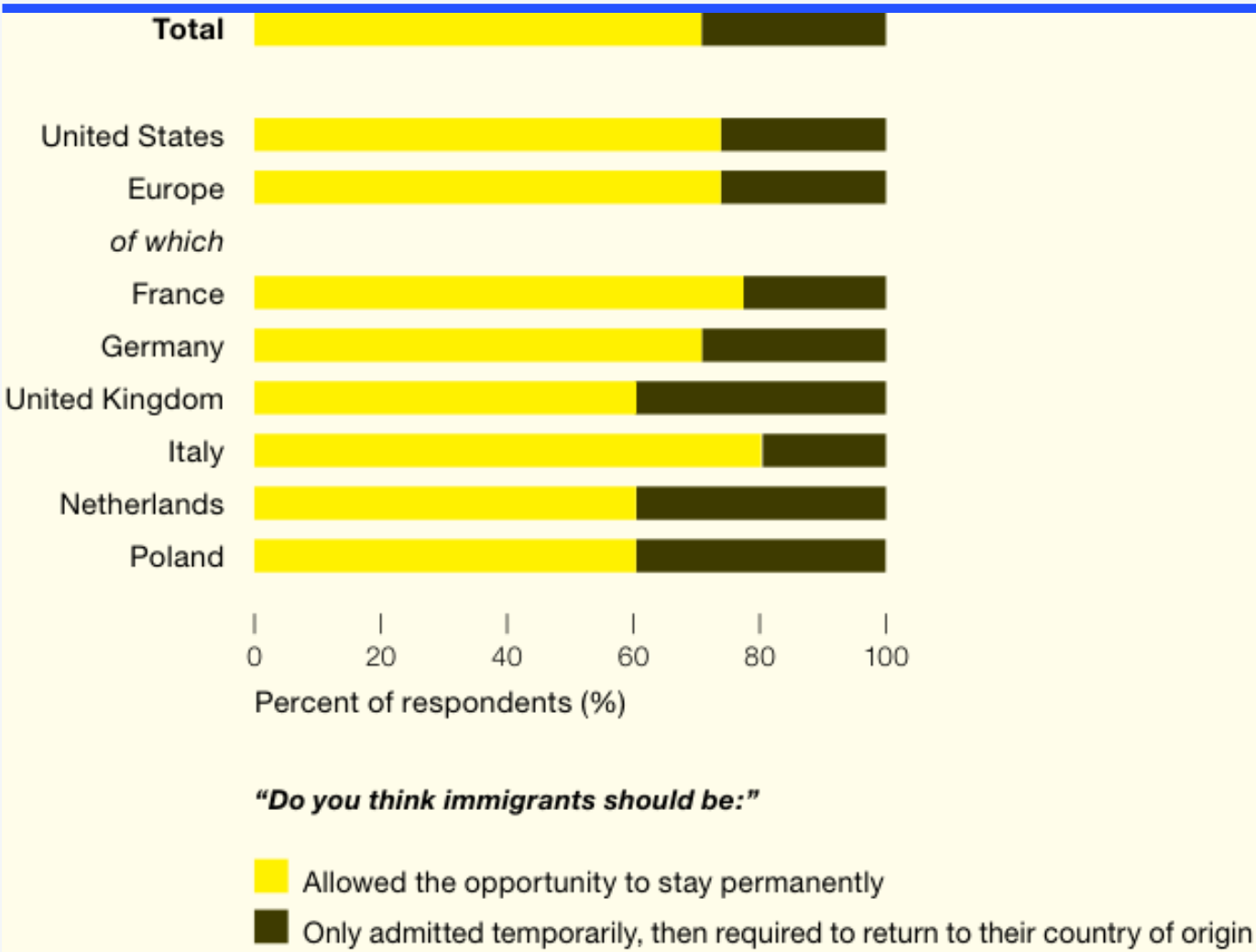


Exhibit. Figure 5.2 Support for opportunity to stay permanently Preferences for temporary versus permanent migration, 2008
Total United States Europe of which France Germany United Kingdom Italy Netherlands Poland 0 20 40 60 80 100 Percent.
Source: S0022.

Climate adaptation as an alternative to migration

Adaptation and migration are not opposites — they are points on a continuum of responses to climate pressure, and the evidence shows them interacting more than substituting. Households receiving remittances have greater long-term social and economic prospects, and remittances can improve disaster recovery and, to some extent, preparedness and adaptation — but their overall contribution to building climate resilience is uncertain. Migration finances adaptation; adaptation, where it works, reduces the need for distressed migration. The loop runs both ways.⁷

Planned retreat is adaptation’s most migration-like form. In São Tomé and Príncipe, the government designed and piloted voluntary population retreat from coastal areas at risk to safer, higher ground for communities in Malanza, Sta. Catarina, and Sundy, where changing wave action, river flood patterns, and sand extraction caused extensive coastal erosion and flooding. This is migration as deliberate policy

rather than desperate flight — the managed-mobility scenario applied to climate displacement, and a model for the low-lying coasts where over a billion people will be at risk by 2050.⁵

Rural-to-urban migration is already functioning as adaptation at scale: rates are high and growing, especially rapidly in Sub-Saharan Africa, the least urbanized region. But adaptation has hard limits. The world is headed toward 2.8°C of warming, not the Paris 2°C goal, with risks rising per increment and possible tipping points. Beyond certain thresholds, in-situ adaptation fails — crops no longer grow, water no longer flows, coasts no longer hold — and migration becomes the only adaptation left. The trapped populations identified earlier are those for whom neither in-situ adaptation nor migration is currently available.⁷²

The policy implication is sequencing, not choosing: invest in adaptation where it can hold (resilient agriculture, water management, coastal protection), enable mobility where it cannot (planned retreat, legal pathways), and use remittances and development to fund both. For the forecast, the adaptation-vs-migration framing is a false binary that the 2.8°C trajectory will keep collapsing — the real question is the mix, and who pays for each part of it.

Findings and recommendations

Key findings

Two hundred years of evidence converge on a set of findings robust enough to anchor the forecast.

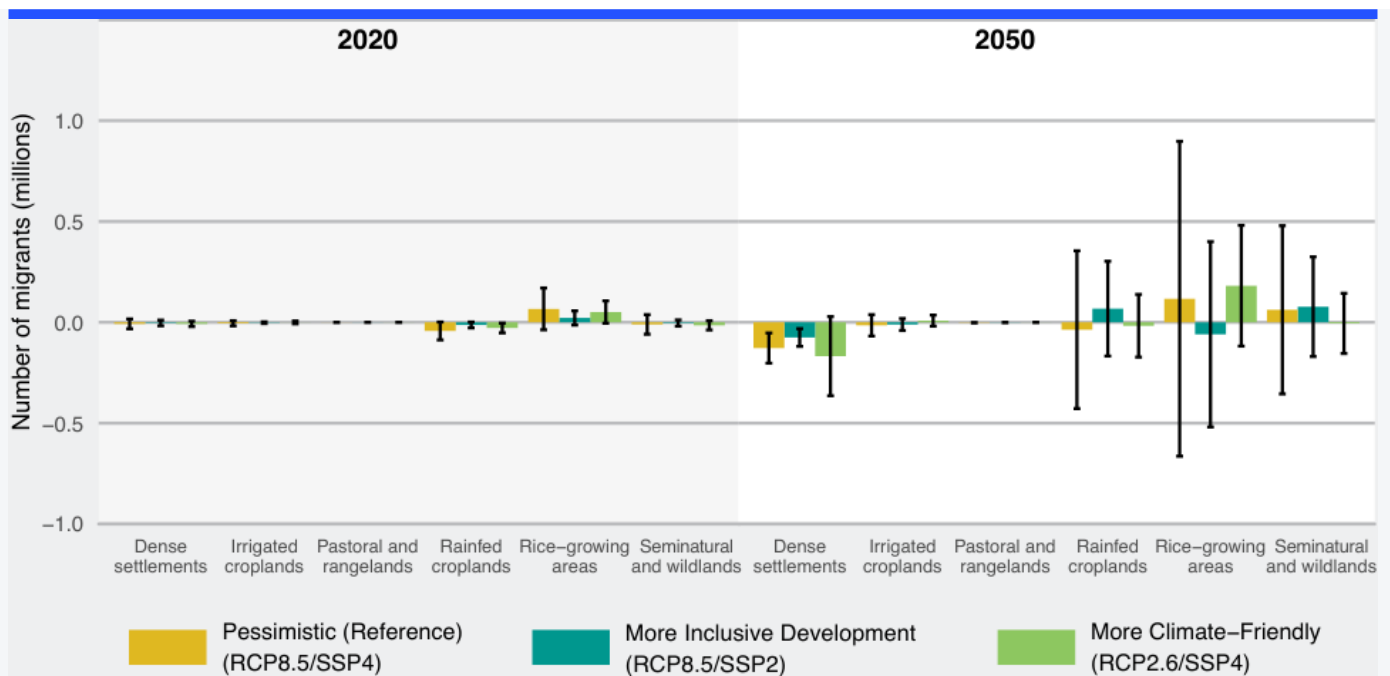
Displacement is at record highs and still rising. Forced displacement reached 123.2 million by end-2024, nearly doubling in a decade. The increase is driven by conflict concentration — a handful of crises producing the majority of refugees — and by the steady accumulation of unresolved situations. Solutions lag catastrophically: 158,700 resettled against tens of millions in need.⁸

Climate migration will reshape internal mobility by 2050. Across Sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia, and Latin America — 55 percent of the developing world’s population — just over 143 million people, around 2.8 percent of these regions’ population, could be forced to move within their countries by 2050 without concrete climate and development action, fleeing less viable areas with lower water availability and crop productivity and rising seas. The poorest and most climate-vulnerable areas will be hardest hit, and hotspots of in- and out-migration will emerge. Country cases sharpen the picture: Bangladesh faces 13.3 million climate migrants on average in the pessimistic scenario; in one focus country, climate migrants could reach 3.1 million (3.1 percent of population) pessimistic versus 1.5 million climate-friendly; in another, up to 2.7 million — 7.7 percent of its 2050 population. Central Asia’s glaciers, projected to shrink 55–75 percent by 2100 with runoff peaking around 2040 before severe shortages, illustrate the slow-onset mechanics.⁷⁵

Development first raises, then lowers emigration. The hump (~\$10,000 GDP/capita) means origin-country growth increases mobility before reducing desperation. Inclusive development — lifting all groups — reduces high-risk migration among the poorest and improves options for voluntary movement; uneven development produces chaotic movements. Climate-exposed countries need adaptation investment; submerging small island states may need special initiatives.²

Policy is the widest uncertainty and the strongest lever. Demography is the most robust forecaster, climate the modeled unknown, but policy choices — legal pathways, enforcement, regularization, rights — determine whether pressure becomes managed mobility or irregular crisis. The evidence consistently favors openness with management: regularization works, rights amplify gains, and restriction manufactures the irregularity it claims to fight.

The scenarios frame the 200-year choice. Managed mobility, fortress fragmentation, or compound crisis — the trends currently favor fragmentation, but the instruments of mobility exist and have been shown to work. The forecast’s key finding is ultimately a choice, not a prediction.



Note: Whiskers show 95th percentile confidence intervals for climate migrants.

Exhibit. Figure 3.21: Projected net migration in and out of livelihood zones in Vietnam in three scenarios, 2020–2050
1. Source: S0005.

Policy recommendations for origin, transit, and destination countries

The evidence in this report points to a differentiated policy agenda — different instruments for origin, transit, and destination countries, joined by bilateral cooperation.

Origin countries should make emigration part of development strategy rather than treating it as failure. Development reduces distressed movements through three channels: stronger resilience to absorb shocks, better skills matching destination needs, and improved origin conditions. Diasporas are development assets: engaging emigrant communities encourages knowledge transfers and global integration, facilitates trade and FDI, and returning migrants bring back skills, assets, and knowledge — governments best facilitate this through a favorable business environment and access to finance. Remittance transfer costs remain the most actionable policy variable.²

Transit countries need responses matched to the varied situations of people passing through — some for days, others for years, some settling before moving on — and to the route-based protection approach for mixed movements. The 2015 European experience is instructive: Europe hosted about one in nine refugees under UNHCR’s mandate (1.8 million), with another million asylum-seekers awaiting outcomes; child asylum applications more than doubled from 2014, and in early 2016 nearly 70 percent of children seeking asylum were fleeing Syria, Afghanistan, and Iraq. With 3.2 million asylum applications pending worldwide at end-2015, transit systems need processing capacity, not just border capacity.²⁸¹⁰

Destination countries should scale legal pathways to labor-market demand through bilateral labor agreements — the MATCH framework: structuring mutually beneficial migration, enhancing skills matching through recognition and development, maximizing gains for all. Labor migration is currently disorganized, driven by individual choices, noneconomic factors, and aggressive brokers rather than labor-market needs; bilateral cooperation corrects this. Standing regularization mechanisms, rights-based integration, and honest fiscal accounting complete the agenda.²

Cross-cutting: implement the Global Compacts’ objectives, invest in data (Objective 1), fund adaptation where it holds and mobility where it doesn’t, and treat the 200-year horizon as a planning input, not a curiosity. The instruments exist; the binding constraint is political will.

The way forward

The way forward begins with seeing the future as regional before it is global. In South Asia, the story is continued densification — fastest along the Indus River and the Gangetic Plain, with Delhi, Dhaka, Lahore, and Karachi growing rapidly on rural migrants — colliding with disasters that displace hundreds of thousands every year: glacial-lake outburst floods, storm surges, droughts, cyclones, heavy precipitation, regularly making India one of the largest displacement counts worldwide. High agricultural dependency means late or failed monsoons threaten livelihoods directly. In Mexico and Central America, rapid population growth and urbanization meet a food system dependent on maize and beans, where rainfed-agriculture households are acutely sensitive to drought and cyclones, pushing family members toward cities

and abroad — migration that demonstrably fluctuates with climate variability. Out-migration from rainfed cropping areas is projected at 200,000–500,000, largest under the pessimistic scenario. Latin America’s climate migrants grow from 1.9–2.7 million in 2020 to 6.9–10.1 million by mid-century — 10.1 million (1.3 percent of population) in the pessimistic case.²

These regional futures are scenario-dependent, and the scenarios are choices. The pessimistic reference (SSP4/RCP8.5) combines high population growth, low GDP growth, and low education in low-income countries with high emissions and high adaptation barriers. The inclusive development scenario holds emissions constant but reduces inequalities and moderates demographic trends. The difference between them — tens of millions of climate migrants — is the measurable value of development policy.⁵

The way forward, then, is the managed-mobility scenario made operational: legal pathways scaled to demographic demand, bilateral labor agreements that match skills to needs, standing regularization, rights-based integration, adaptation where it holds and mobility where it doesn’t, development that converts distressed flight into chosen mobility. The instruments exist; the evidence favors them; the binding constraint is political will.

Two hundred years from 1826, migration will have continued — the one constant in this report’s two centuries of waves. Whether the next two centuries bring managed mobility or compound crisis is not written in the demography or the climate models. It will be written in policy choices made in the next two decades. The forecast is a choice. This report’s final recommendation is to make it deliberately.

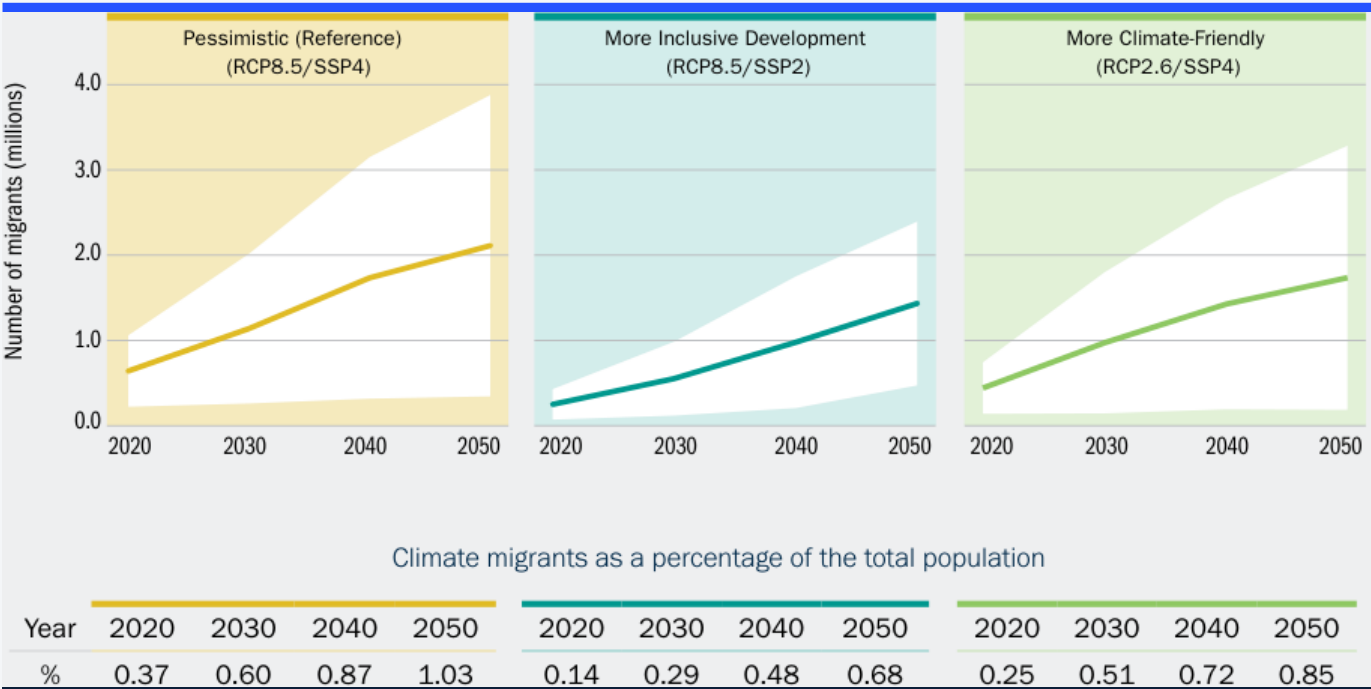


Exhibit. Figure 4.23: Projected number of internal climate migrants in Mexico and Central America under three scenarios Pessimistic (Reference) More Inclusive Development More Climate-Friendly (RCP8. Source: S0006.

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